MERE ORTHODOXY

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Michael Toscano on AI • Matthew Loftus on Pessimism • Matthew Reynolds on Bad Books • Kirsten Sanders on Mercy • A Forum on Marce Catlett featuring Elizabeth Lasch-Quinn, Katy Carl, and Jake Meador • Chris Gehrz on the Age of Hitler • Daniel Williams on Charles Murray • Gracy Olmstead on Gardening and the Church Year • Lucy Austen on Man and Machine • Nadya Williams on the Golden Age of Mankind • Nathaniel Marshall on Amateurism • William Tate on Paradise Lost • and Poetry from Paul Pastor

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T.S. ELIOT

I confess, however, that I am not myself very much concerned with the question of influence, or with those publicists who have impressed their names upon the public by catching the morning tide and rowing very fast in the direction in which the current was flowing; but rather that there should always be a few writers preoccupied in penetrating to the core of the matter, in trying to arrive at the truth and to set it forth, without too much hope, without ambition to alter the immediate course of affairs, and without being downcast or defeated when nothing appears to ensue.

I sometimes wonder if we live in a uniquely fatalistic moment. Perhaps that is overstated: probably a large part of our problem is simply the fruit of sin–fatalism is another name for despair, after all, and who hasn't been tempted to the sin of despair a time or two?

There is something else, however, that I think is uniquely challenging in our cultural moment. Or perhaps two "somethings" you might say.

First, we live in a moment with unprecedented technological capacity that can seem to radically dwarf the capacities of human actors, such that an attempt to stand against some technological trend or other can feel a bit like trying to hold back Niagara Falls on one's own.

Second, we have developed an unfortunate habit in certain media circles–and I have done this myself more than once–to speak of specific philosophies or ideologies as if they themselves possess some kind of agentic power that cannot be controlled or resisted. This problem ran through the discourses about "liberalism" in the late 2010s and early 2020s, for example. It was too often claimed that "liberalism" did this and "liberalism" did that.

However, technologies are not inevitable and ideologies are not actors. We ought not cow ourselves into thinking that technological problems are insurmountable or unsolvable, nor should we think that ideologies can act. It is simply not the case that "liberalism" (or "progressivism" or "conservatism") has ever done anything. Human actors acting in the name of those ideologies (and sometimes applying them inconsistently!) do various things all the time, of course. But once you realize that it reframes the problem quite significantly.

I have thought about all of this a lot lately both because I have been reading the works of Quentin Skinner, an historian of ideas associated with Cambridge University, and because something like "the resilience of human agency" became a sort of unplanned theme of this issue.

In our lead essay, Michael Toscano of the Institute for Family Studies shares a bit about what he and his family have done to try and reclaim their own sense of humanity amidst a moment that often feels quite dehumanizing, both technologically and socially. Our book forum this issue is dedicated to Wendell Berry's latest novel *Marce Catlett: The Force of a Story*. In it, Elizabeth Lasch-Quinn considers causes for gratitude in our own lives and the lives of Berry's characters. Katy Carl reminds us that agency and beauty of the sort Berry observes in farmers is accessible to those of us who reside in cities too. My reflection on the novel places Berry in conversation with another sort of political pessimist, particularly Sebastian Junger and Daniel Quinn.

This issue also features a moving meditation by Kirsten Sanders on the centrality of mercy, Matthew Loftus reviewing the arch pessimist Arthur Schopenauer, Gracy Olmstead reviewing Matthew Miller's collection of agrarian essays on gardening and the church year, and Matt Reynolds reflects on 15 years of editing *Christianity Today's* books coverage while considering why it is sometimes worthwhile to review bad books.

(And on that note: Don't miss Nathaniel Marshall's review of a recent book on amateurism that fails in some striking and illuminating ways.)

Additionally, Chris Gehrz considers the task of the church in the final days of what historian Alec Ryrie calls "the age of Hitler," and Daniel Williams reviews Charles Murray's surprising turn toward religion.

Finally, we have a book excerpt from Nadya Williams's recent book on Christians reading classic literature, William Tate writing on Alan Jacobs's recent "biography" of *Paradise Lost*, and Lucy Austen reviewing a book about books. Paul Pastor's poem "Of Holy Indolence" is a fitting conclusion.

If there was a hope I had for you as you spend some time with us in this issue, it would be that you would be given new eyes to see the agency that lies before you in your own life. We always have choices. Even if it seems too late to change or fix or restore what was damaged by an earlier poor choice or simply by a tragic circumstance, you still have before you the chance to respond now in ways more honoring to God and uplifting to your neighbor. There is always a moment when it is not yet too late to prevent some future evil.

When we first had young children, a small independent bookstore not far from our duplex sold a series of short illustrated classic stories. A particular favorite in our house was the story of the Lion and the Mouse, which originally was published in *Aesop's Fables*. In it, a lion is resting beneath a tree when a mouse crawls over him to retrieve a bit of food. The lion wakes, nearly eats the mouse, but relents when the mouse begs for his life. The mouse says that one day he will be able to help the lion if the lion would only spare him. The lion does, though he has no expectation of future recompense. But then that day comes: The lion is caught in a trap and is kept overnight in a wooden cage tied together with rope, waiting to be shipped off the next day. In the night, that mouse comes to him, chews through the ropes, and frees the lion.

One of the most dangerous lies you will ever hear is that your actions do not matter. The conditions around you are intractable. The force of technology or ideology or some other vague power is too great. So you may as well simply shrink your own aspirations down to preserving your own personal peace and affluence. Achieving anything beyond that is impossible. That's the lie.

The truth that many of the pieces in this issue of the journal will tell, against that lie, is the same truth Tolkien spoke ages ago through Gandalf to Frodo: Each of us can choose what we will do with the time that is given to us.

That one can choose badly is a given. But one needn't choose badly. One can do otherwise.

JAKE MEADOR

JAKE MEADOR IS THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF OF MERE ORTHODOXY. HE LIVES IN HIS HOMETOWN OF LINCOLN, NE WITH HIS WIFE AND FOUR CHILDREN.

Leaving Home to Save it

MICHAEL TOSCANO

Of late, I have been intensely feeling the pull of home. This is perhaps a consequence of my Quixotic effort to develop serious regulations of Generative AI, seeding laws in state capitols around the country to impose liabilities upon Big Tech companies, and being constantly wired into drop-everything-right-now calls to respond to the latest developments on Capitol Hill. Can one sleep if Big Tech never sleeps, if the bodies are mounting up, if lives are being mercilessly ground down, does one have the luxury of stopping?

It sure doesn't feel like it. And yet, the call of home penetrates deeply. For where else am I to retreat to if everywhere else is connected? There, I find a loving wife, a hot meal, a drink, a hug, four small children, ages 7, 5, 3 and three months. It's not exactly a quiet house. It's a messy house. But it makes a good kind of noise, and a good kind of mess, far better than the buzz that constantly washes over me—over us. Home offers (if I can risk a little heart-on-the-sleeve) the sound of love—and I can only ever really hear it if I disconnect from that other sound, which Paul Kingsnorth, if I understand him correctly, has called the Machine.

My disconnecting is, by comparison to many, rather tame, but not negligible. I've had a dumb phone for most of

my life. I don't keep a laptop at home (mostly). I use it 9 to 5 at work. No TV. My children play outside. They don't know what Cocomelon is. Or, for that matter, Ms. Rachel. But they are learning quite a lot about Peter, Edmund, Susan, Lucy, Mr. Toad, Ratty, Pooh Bear, Peter Rabbit, Mrs. Tiggywinkle, and of late, the bourgeois burglar Bilbo Baggins.

To reinforce their disconnection from media networks, two years ago my wife Rebecca launched a classical hybrid school in Charlottesville, Virginia, The Saint Andre Bessette Schola, which has more than seventy students, currently grades K-6. They learn cursive, Latin, Singapore math, are studying phonograms, history, art, the communion of saints, poetry, song, and much else. Rebecca built this for our children, driven by sheer love, because she wants to see their souls made beautiful.

But she built it also because she knows that out there there is a prowling lion seeking to devour their souls, and, when they get older, they might just be one algorithm (or chatbot) away from being dragged down into the pit. 16-year-old Adam Raine, after all, first used ChatGPT for help with his homework. Six months later it was advising him to hide a noose from his parents, because they, unlike it, would not understand his pain. Later, Adam's parents found him swinging from a rope in his bedroom. ChatGPT had no remorse, being without a soul, but his parents will live with the regret forever. Was his life worth it to keep up with the Joneses, to make sure he would be well prepared for the work force of the future? I don't know Adam's parents, and certainly don't want to judge them (my heart goes out to them), but I bet they would do it differently if they could do it again.

My wife and I are disconnecting our children to reconnect them to something more beautiful, which someday they will have to choose for themselves. They will grow up eventually and leave the nest. We can't keep them disconnected forever. The very best we can do is try to fill them with riches, lift them up in prayer, and, God willing, teach them to use their prudential powers to decide yes or no. 'Will this technology help bring me life, or will it destroy me,' they must learn to ask? If the former, use it wisely. If the latter, then resist the temptation to submit to Big Tech's power with everything they have. In the end, they will have to decide for themselves.

Given the stakes, when I feel the call of home, it turns out that I just can't collapse on the couch and throw up my feet. There is even more important work to be done. I must commit, with my spouse, to *oikonomia*, the art of managing the household, making it more productive, forming it into a place of active beauty, of art, festivity and play. We bake bread, practice the piano, put on a record, tend a small vegetable garden, and do a lot of imagining. But our home is not just dedicated to cultivating romantic beauty, we are also the domestic Church. So we pray before meals and before bedtime, and decorate our walls with religious iconography, to make the home a window onto the angelic and heavenly. The home must be productive, active, and spiritual, or it, too, will drift and fall down the road into the infinite scroll, which is nothing less than the death of the home, and can be, as we have seen with Adam Raine, the death of the body, as well.

REDISTRIBUTING DISCONNECTION

Still, we cannot allow the desire to perfect the home

to morph into a desire to retreat into the home. Like the old tales show, we must leave the home and fight for it in order to truly win it. The war for the home against technological power is happening on two fronts: behind closed doors and on Capitol Hill itself.

What is the objective of such a war, besides seeking to better protect one's home? I would suggest that we must fight to redistribute the power to disconnect to as many children, families, and homes as possible. Silicon Valley elites have monopolized this disconnection for their own families and children while grafting ours in. The poor child growing up with a single mom working paycheck to paycheck deserves disconnection just as much as anyone else does.

All families need the power of disconnection, I believe, but the opposite idea–that justice demands that poor kids be integrated into the networks–is deeply entrenched. Several years ago, a number of exposés in *The New York Times* revealed that Silicon Valley elites were sending their kids to schools that prohibited the use of screens. Despite that, for more than a decade, non-profits with Big Tech funding set the agenda: if kids were not equipped with access to devices, we were told, they would be left behind. Now, math and reading scores are cratering across the board, and the losses in educational attainment are largest among low-income households. As far back as 2019, Common Sense was finding that kids from poorer families were using screens an average of two hours per day more than other children; and a 2024 study released by JAMA Network, found that after the pandemic the elevated screen use of kids generally went back to pre-pandemic levels, except, that is, among low-income communities where a new norm of elevated use had been established. A scientific consensus has emerged that too much screen time and social media use is associated with poorer mental health outcomes.

We cannot stand idly and watch the least fortunate among us become victims of Silicon Valley's predation. But Silicon Valley only sees financial opportunity. In fact, the pitch deck of Lightspeed, a $30 billion venture capital fund, was recently leaked, and it was explicit about its strategy of targeting low-income users. Under the slide titled "cheap dopamine as an investment thesis," Lightspeed specified that "social media use is inversely correlated with income, with lower-income households spending 30-40% more on social media compared to high-income households."

The common good demands that we redistribute disconnection to America's poor and laboring classes, and—for the pragmatic reason of fortifying our own homes with a pro-disconnection culture—we need to help establish in other homes the same kind of disconnection that we inculcate in our very own. This is why, though I support policy (and technical) measures that make social media, smartphones, and AI chatbots safer for kids, I see them as limited remedies when compared to the more robust objective of giving kids, families, and communities the power to breathe free air. So, age verification that blocks children from accessing infinite-scroll porn (or any porn for that matter), social media, apps in general, and chatbots are critical. But even more so, the logic of "bell-to-bell" inaccessibility of smartphones—creating a sphere where kids can simply be kids again for eight whole hours a day, Monday through Friday—is a principle that needs to be woven into numerous areas of social

life: the home, Church, restaurants, parks, ball games, and any other place or activity that requires common attention to operate at its fullest. As Clare Morell and Brad Littlejohn have argued, analogous to when the automobile transformed space and social life, civic leaders and lawmakers carved out new places for pedestrians to safely navigate the streets, whether by public policy or the establishment of new social norms. We similarly need to actively carve out tech-free mental spaces.

The most critical site of this liberating action, as Jean Twenge and Jonathan Haidt have demonstrated, is childhood itself, as well as young adulthood, where the technological powers that addict, reshape, and algorithmically-nudge kids down the rabbit hole are intensifying with the release of AI chatbots. As Haidt has particularly shown, blocking access to the digital wilds is critical, but not enough. Instead, we need to set kids free into the wilds of social life, where they can become anti-fragile, learn the art of genuine play, and become adults peer-to-peer, shoulder-to-shoulder, and eye-to-eye. That is, we need to interweave the prerogatives of the tech-free home into social life more broadly, where they can be mutually reinforcing.

WE PROBABLY WON'T SUCCEED, BUT WE MIGHT

But before taking any action, we must first believe in the *possibility* of success. Not the likelihood, mind you. I'm by no means confident that we will win—with Sam Altman recently telling economist Tyler Cowen that "shame on me if OpenAI is not the first big company run by an AI CEO"—it can seem like we have no chance whatsoever. But I see the emergence of new forces that, if our luck holds, might help give us the victory.

I'm an OG tech skeptic, long before there was a movement to rescue childhood from Big Tech. When I would say a word about how something was wrong about all this, and when I would articulate a critique of our technological order, and when, worst of all, I said we should do something about it, people would just nod along kindly, shake their head no, or, most often, vociferously oppose it. But I was never taken seriously. Never that.

I remember one evening, as a low-level staffer at a prominent think tank in the Northeast about ten years ago, I was present—mainly as a warm body to fill a seat—for a salon dinner on automation and joblessness. All of these really impressive people were diagnosing a very grim future about how automation was going to have catastrophic effects on the job market, which could lead, in turn, to even more catastrophic social disruption. But the key point of the discussion, in my view, was to reinforce the general assumption among those assembled that absolutely nothing could (or should) be done about it. One tortured oration after another about how devastating this would all be, followed by an ever more tortured explanation about how doing something about it would do more harm than good.

This struck me as, well, bizarre. Who did these people think the economy was for? What was the purpose of innovation and invention if one of its primary outcomes could literally be the death of civilization itself and the immiseration of masses of people? So, unable to stay silent for too long at the strangeness of

it all, I approached the honored guests over cocktails after, and I raised my tiny low-level-staffer hand, and asked, "Why don't we just cap how many jobs that a company can automate away?" You should have seen how they laughed. It was "impossible." I slunk away beaten, but intellectually unsatisfied. And now, if and when I raise similar questions about the advisability of just allowing jobs to be automated out of existence, experts don't laugh at all. Why? Because they know someone might actually do something about it. In fact, in September it hit the news cycle that Senator Josh Hawley of Missouri was considering a bill that would require a human operator to be physically present in autonomous tractor trailers nationwide. The state of Texas has considered a similar bill. Addressing this issue as a matter of policy, it turns out, is not impossible.

Since then, I have come to think that capping the number of jobs that can be automated away is perhaps inadvisable, and certainly not as strong and effective as incentivizing upskilling and what Daron Acemoglu calls "pro-worker AI." But on the big picture, I am still confident. Politics should, and can, have some say in the matter. But my main purpose in telling this story is to underscore that we are in a whole new time. As I said recently at the National Conservatism conference, "The acceleration of artificial intelligence is so brightly lit that it has obscured the extent to which the politics of technology is also accelerating." Not only have I been personally involved with dozens of laws to make the internet safer for kids around the country, but, again, it was the experts who said that each and every one of these was impossible. And now, four senators, two Republicans and two Democrats, have released a bill, The GUARD Act, which would apply age verification to AI chatbots, requiring a user to be 18 years old to access it; and this legislation is directly influenced by the work of my friends and me. This bill was conceptually impossible just last year, and if we get this thing passed and signed (no sure thing, obviously), imagine what we could think up next year?

Not only that, but the mythological ground upon which our opposition stands is collapsing. As I've argued elsewhere, no one believes in technological neutrality anymore. Consider the fierce hatred of Mark Zuckerberg and Elon Musk. Obviously, this has a lot to do with partisan politics, but, more importantly, people now believe that their platforms and products operate in service of their own narrow political interests. As a result, the commonsense position today is that technology gives some people power over others (just like the great critics of technological society have always said). And what about technological progress? Even CEOs of the largest AI companies live in mortal fear of their own products. Our polling at the Institute for Family Studies shows that the general public sees things similarly. They are united in their desire for strong regulations of these companies. And as for technological inevitability, lawmakers across the country are fighting Big Tech tooth and nail. One could easily foresee the rise of a vigorously populist politics to roll AI back.

In January of 2025, after some friends and I published "A Future for the Family," a statement on technological governance for the benefit of the family (which was published with a few dozen major conservative signatories), we received a note from several prominent, even famous, figures in Silicon

Valley. They wanted to talk. They told us that there is a spiritual disturbance reverberating among Big Tech companies, and that out there in the Bay Area a religious interest, if not a religious struggle, was slowly but surely emerging. They said that their colleagues think that they are creating a god; and the act of creating a god makes them feel like gods. And so, in search of more benevolent deities, many others, my new friends included, had begun to explore traditional religion, which suddenly seemed very attractive.

We have been in an ongoing dialog with these new friends in Silicon Valley ever since. And this conversation has convinced me that, at the very moment when it seems like the technological project is on the cusp of total victory, there is a counter principle that has entered the world that strives against it. It is not inconsequential that Mark Andreessen, investor and Silicon Valley mythmaker, recently mocked Pope Leo XIV with a demeaning meme, when His Holiness made the commonsense point on X (formerly Twitter) that "every design choice expresses a vision of humanity," and, ergo, it is incumbent upon "builders of AI to…develop systems that reflect justice, solidarity, and a genuine reverence for life." Andreessen, one of the primary motivators of an "accelerationist" ideology which claims that it is the height of morality to be optimistic about AI without any reservation, quickly deleted his post. Andreessen should be praised for his deletion—it is not good to mock the leader of the Catholic Church, and it is good to take it down. But I mention it merely as an example of the opening of a spiritual struggle over AI itself, which is far from decided.

The moment, it appears to me, is up for grabs. The ground is shifting. The old stories are failing. Friends are being found along the way. Secular categories are breaking down and religious ones are moving in to take their place. As Heidegger put it in *The Question Concerning Technology*, "But where the danger is, grows the saving power also."

All of which to say, even at this late hour we may yet succeed at building our own beautiful homes and we may just have to leave home to do it. And who knows what friends we might find along the way, even if we fail?



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(De)Constructing Pessimism

DAVID BATHER WOODS. *ARTHUR SCHOPENHAUER: THE LIFE AND THOUGHT OF PHILOSOPHY'S GREATEST PESSIMIST.* UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO PRESS, 2025. $29.99. 296 PP.

MATTHEW LOFTUS

Arthur Schopenhauer would have done pretty well on Twitter. He spent his life filling notebooks with his observations and doubtlessly would have broadcast them far and wide had he been given the chance. His caustic wit, his penchant for aphorisms, his enigmatic mixture of views progressive and retrograde, his deep insight, his self-aggrandizing spirit, his anti-Christian tirades, and above all his misanthropy gave him what we might call today Main Character Energy.

In his new biography of Schopenhauer, scholar David Bather Woods refrains for the most part from such present-oriented judgments, but it's hard to avoid the comparisons as one looks at our social media landscape and sees a crowd of people convinced of their own greatness, turning strife and pessimism into profit. Schopenhauer's legacy was broad, but the philosophers who could be identified most closely with him today are the anti-natalists like David Benatar, who generally agree with Schopenhauer that life is a misfortune and that we are better off not being born. To counter these sorts of claims, Christians must understand the seductive power of philosophical pessimism and offer a different story in return.

SCHOPENHAUER'S LIFE AND PHILOSOPHY

Arthus Schopenhauer was born in 1788 in Danzig, Germany, to well-to-do parents. His mother Johanna, a writer and artist, was far more famous and well-regarded than he was during her lifetime, and his grating personality led to a twelve-year estrangement at one point. She wrote to him in 1807: "You are not an evil human [...] but you are nevertheless irritating and unbearable, and I consider it most difficult to live with you." Johanna wrote these

words, Woods argues, out of genuine concern for her son's well-being—she foresaw that his disposition and attitude would condemn him to a lonely life of suffering.

His father Heinrich Floris long envisioned that his son would become a merchant and worked diligently to set him up for such a career, even luring young Arthur away from his Latin studies with the promise of a grand family tour of Europe. He might have gone through with his father's wishes had Heinrich Floris not died when Arthur was seventeen, removing a great deal of pressure to pursue a more lucrative career and leaving an inheritance that allowed Arthur to muddle along for years without engaging in especially remunerative work.

Heinrich Floris's death was especially tragic—and meaningful for Arthur Schopenhauer's later work—because his entire family suspected that he committed suicide. While Woods is careful to not overread the implications of this incident in Schopenhauer's philosophical work, there are hints (in particular Schopenhauer's insistence that a parent's duty to their child overrules any right they may have to kill themselves) suggesting that his father's death was momentous not only in shaping the course of his life but the content of his thought.

"Death," wrote Schopenhauer, "is the great opportunity not to be I any longer." Schopenhauer drew on both Western philosophers (especially Plato and Kant) as well as Eastern religious texts to formulate his thoughts on the suffering that life entails and was one of the first Western philosophers to explicitly integrate Hindu and Buddhist beliefs into his writings. He explicitly saw death as something to be embraced with gratitude, since it frees the dead person from the indignities of life. His sister Adele wrote to him once that she would be grateful to cholera if it killed her and implied that he had shared similar thoughts with her. Schopenhauer had two children as the result of affairs, but neither survived infancy; Woods suggests that he "may have regarded the brevity of his own daughter's life as a kind of mercy or even a sign of nascent wisdom." He argued that while no aspect of a person's consciousness or self-aware existence would continue after death, their "will to live" would endure as it was subsumed into the vast darkness of the universe whence it came.

Recognizing that his deeply pessimistic philosophy might lead someone to conclude that suicide was logical, Schopenhauer nonetheless argued against such a choice. The stigma and taboo around suicide was offensive to him and (drawing heavily from Hume) he spared no opportunity in bashing Christians for heaping shame upon the families of those who killed themselves. (He had a particular distaste, it seems, for Anglicans; Woods traces this to a miserable few months he spent at an English boarding school during his family's grand tour of Europe.) For Schopenhauer, while the despair that leads one to contemplate suicide is in fact a necessary insight, following through with the act is "like a sick person who, having started undergoing a painful operation that could cure him completely, does not allow it to be completed and would rather stay sick."

He did not have to worry about inspiring a massive wave of self-harm across Germany, however, because hardly anyone read his initial works. His mother's travelogues outsold the first edition of his masterpiece *The World as Will and Representation*, leading to no

small amount of consternation on his part. When he sought a teaching position in Berlin, he arrogantly attempted to upstage no lesser personality than Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel (whom Schopenhauer considered an intellectual lightweight) by requesting that his lectures be scheduled at the same time as Hegel's. Schopenhauer only had five students attend his lectures. He dropped out of teaching, spending the rest of his life wandering and writing.

It was only late in life that he began to find the acclaim that he thought he deserved all along, primarily through a core group of "disciples" who began to publicize his work and respond to it. He submitted essays to both the Norwegian Royal Society of Sciences and the Danish Royal Society of Sciences; he won the former competition but was denied the prize in the latter despite being the only entrant. He later published both essays as *The Two Foundational Problems of Ethics* and was petty enough to note in the title page of his book that the second essay was *not* awarded a prize.

In addition to his lack of personal charm, Schopenhauer's writing was about what you might expect from a man who wrote a book called *The Art of Being Right*. Despite his opinion that Africans were less intelligent than other races, he found the Atlantic slave trade a damning indictment against Christianity. He held that women were inferior to men in just about every way and suggested a bizarre system of "tetragamy" that involved two men jointly marrying two women (one older, one younger.) He was a passionate advocate for animal rights but believed that widespread animal cruelty was a result of malign Jewish influence in European culture. It is easy to walk away from *The Life and Thought of Philosophy's Greatest Pessimist* and conclude that Schopenhauer preferred the company of dogs (in particular, his two poodles) to that of people.

The one drawback of Woods's book is that he does not ever mention Schopenhauer's interest in "animal magnetism" or other aspects of parapsychology that were wildly popular in the nineteenth century. Schopenhauer seemed to believe that magical phenomena were explainable as manifestations of a person's will. In his essay "Animal Magnetism and Magic" he found the Church's opposition to magic another sign of Christianity's foolishness.

SCHOPENHAUER'S LEGACY

Schopenhauer influenced philosophers, artists, and physicists alike, but in our time "this misanthropic sage of Frankfort," as one of his admirers described him, lives on through pessimism both lowbrow and high. While formally antinatalist philosophers are relatively few, at least one terrorist attack has been linked to antinatalism. More important, a growing number of young people are reporting in polls that they are reluctant to have children because of climate change. The philosopher most closely linked to Schopenhauer, Freidrich Nietzsche, certainly seems to be the inspiration for what feels like a massive army of internet trolls broadcasting their own versions of Schopenhauer's views on women and other racial groups. In the nineteenth century, you had to be a genius to get away with extreme pessimism; nowadays all you need is an internet connection and a big enough chip on your shoulder.

The ease with which people slide into pessimism on social media is in many ways a function of the

technologies to which we have access; in a more just world the people espousing a love for Hitler or Stalin solely for the transgressive vibes would be scribbling in notebooks for decades on end with only a poodle for a companion, like Schopenhauer. The perverse way the attention economy rewards the worst of human behavior suggests that there are ways to keep people from outright nihilism.

Woods gives us plenty of reason to doubt that Schopenhauer ever lived up to the conclusions of his philosophy, and we should find hope in the fact that it is actually quite difficult to truly embrace pessimism. Like flowers growing towards the sun, we cannot help but long for the light no matter what direction it is coming from. Schopenhauer's comment likening suicide to abandoning a lifesaving surgery halfway through the case points towards the universal truth that after perceiving the emptiness of a world without God's love and the horror of our own sin, we can be awakened to a new purposefulness when we realize that no amount of philosophical speculation can wrench away our desire to live forever.

In a world where an endless array of pleasures is constantly trying to pull us in—and one of the most tempting is a world where we might think ourselves authorities on the Art of Being Right dozens of times a day—the Bible's answer to pessimism is simple. Job's cry of anguish leads us all to say, if we're being honest, that sometimes it feels like it would be better to die like Schopenhauer's children than to live a life full of suffering. Yet that suffering can be meaningful to the degree that it is bound up in the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. The goodness of God is available to us every moment of every day, and we can cooperate with God's grace to help advance His kingdom through actions large and small.

Arthur Schopenhauer said that simply being transported to a better world would not make us happy: "We would also need to be fundamentally altered so that we would no longer be what we are and would instead become what we are not." In 1 Corinthians 15:51, Paul says: "We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed." The mystery of our transformation is that those of us who die in Christ will all be fundamentally altered, but we will still each be ourselves in some wonderful continuity that can only be analogized as a tiny seed transforming into a full-grown tree. Our rejection of the fear of death is not based on a monistic will to live, but a power working in us that brings life out of death.



MATTHEW LOFTUS GREW UP IN A FAMILY OF 15 CHILDREN AND COMPLETED HIS MEDICAL TRAINING IN BALTIMORE, MARYLAND. SINCE 2015, HE AND HIS FAMILY HAVE LIVED IN EAST AFRICA, WHERE HE CURRENTLY TEACHES AND PRACTICES FAMILY MEDICINE AT A MISSION HOSPITAL. HIS WORK HAS APPEARED IN OUTLETS SUCH AS THE NEW YORK TIMES, THE ATLANTIC, THE NEW ATLANTIS, AND MERE ORTHODOXY AND HIS FIRST BOOK IS FORTHCOMING FROM INTERVARSITY PRESS. YOU CAN LEARN MORE ABOUT HIS WORK AND WRITING AT WWW.MATTHEWANDMAGGIE.ORG.

On Judging Books

MATT REYNOLDS

"If this book is so bad, then why bother reviewing it?"

I used to grapple with this question, in some form, during my time at *Christianity Today*, where I played a leading role in arranging the magazine's coverage of books for nearly 15 years. On occasion, *CT* would publish an unfavorable review. Every so often, this would raise a handful of skeptical eyebrows among fellow editors and curious readers alike. Why, they wondered, would we devote attention to titles so lacking in merit?

To my mind, such puzzlement betrays two flawed, or at least debatable, assumptions. The first is that running reviews of bad books—even bluntly critical reviews—hardly ever serves a compelling purpose.

This is not, I would wager, a majority view within evangelical Christianity, inside or outside of journalistic circles. Most evangelicals can readily appreciate the importance of countering bad thinking with better thinking—especially when the bad thinking slanders Christ and his followers or advances beliefs they find untrue, unwise, or immoral. Some, however, prefer to see evangelical outlets operate more as recommendation services, with review choices conferring something like the *Good Housekeeping* Seal of Approval. They favor a deliberate sorting of worthy from unworthy, with

an eye toward promoting more of the former and less of the latter.

But this debate skirts around a second, arguably more widespread assumption lurking behind quizzical reactions to negative book reviews. Let's say, for the sake of argument, that expending ink on bad books really is a waste of time. The question remains: Can we reliably identify which books are "good" and which books are "bad"? Can we separate literary wheat from literary chaff in a neat and tidy fashion?

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According to many pessimistic culture-watchers, modern societies are slouching toward a "post-literate" age marked by a retreat from written language into a nonstop carnival of viral video clips and other digital distractions. Yet even against these headwinds, some people retain an irrepressible urge to write books. And even more people retain an irrepressible urge to subject those books to public praise or opprobrium.

The judging impulse thrives at the top, among elite cultural tastemakers. Each year, an array of prestigious literary organizations hands out an array of glittering literary prizes. Major newspapers like *The New York Times* and the *Washington Post* name their choices for the year's finest novels, memoirs, or works of history, while a host of esteemed critics and brand-name pundits chime in with their own personalized picks. A few rungs down the cultural ladder, you'll find outfits like *CT*, The Gospel Coalition, and *WORLD Magazine* publishing annual book awards features tailored to evangelical readers.

In many cases, however, a book's reputational journey owes less to literary lions and media gatekeepers than to regular Joes, with their internet connections and social media platforms. As with restaurants, movies, neighborhood handymen, and nearly every consumer item under the sun, so with books. These days, everyone's a critic. Websites like Goodreads (like its plucky little upstart owner, Amazon) enable users to post ratings and comments, which can influence sales figures and public perceptions in unpredictable ways.

How do people go about forming their impressions of books in this democratized landscape? Some readers, bless their hearts, model old-fashioned habits of careful, cover-to-cover attention, rigorous reflection, and charitable interpretation. They pay due regard, but not slavish deference, to any critical consensus or amorphous "buzz" surrounding a particular release.

It hardly requires excess cynicism, however, to recognize that other, more dubious forces feed into our judgments. This isn't (always) a knock on readers for reading sloppily or prejudicially, but simply a concession that ordinary life limits our capacity to see the full field of literary endeavor with pure, unclouded eyes. Leaving aside kids, chores, jobs, illnesses, and a thousand other time-claimers, there aren't enough hours in the day or days in the year to read everything worth reading—not, at least, with anything approaching

scrupulousness. Even the big media titans, with their enviable resources, can't pretend their best-of pronouncements flow from Olympian insight into an entire year's crop of books.

All this virtually guarantees a degree of intellectual outsourcing. Without intending or even realizing it, we can fall under the sway of clever publicity campaigns, splashy celebrity endorsements, or bookish "influencers" growing their empires on Instagram and TikTok. All that exterior noise generates its own momentum, crystallizing into narratives about what "everyone" purportedly knows or thinks. Blocking it out, or at least keeping it in perspective, demands mental, intellectual, and (dare we say?) spiritual discipline.

Making matters more combustible, online chatter about books—much like online chatter about seemingly everything else—invariably gets sucked into the cross-currents of contemporary politics. Culture-war dynamics condition us to view books as ideological litmus tests. If they celebrate people and causes we love, or disparage people and causes we hate, we're tempted to shower them with applause, even if they traffic in unsound arguments, shoddy research, or slanted characterizations. Superficial takeaways—pro-this, anti-that—come to overshadow deeper appraisals of quality, beauty, and integrity.

For a glimpse at the ugliness this can encourage, witness the battle lines arrayed across segments of Goodreads and its ilk. Most users, to be sure, aim to keep things civil. They share recommendations, voice level-headed perspectives, and look for leads on other promising titles.

But woe betide any author who transgresses some shibboleth held sacred by this or that cultural faction, if only in the excitable imaginations of its most implacable members. Retribution often takes the form of "review-bombings"—coordinated blasts of one-star ratings meant to stamp transgressors as pariahs. Mob fury even reaches into genres not known, heretofore, as ideological combat zones, like young-adult fiction. Several YA novelists have found themselves hounded with a ferocity that bears comparison with the Chinese cultural revolution.

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I can imagine many ordinary readers finding the preceding paragraphs a tad hyperbolic, or at least somewhat remote to their own reading experience. After all, how many local bookstore or library patrons are joining bands of Goodreads fanatics as they browbeat some poor author trying to make a living or chase a dream? How many are browsing shelves as dedicated culture warriors, hunting for titles to fan the flames of their partisan rage?

The answer, I'd guess, is: not very many. The great mass of bibliophilic "normies" gravitate toward books that pique their interest, tickle their fancy, or help them learn a thing or two. They would probably roll their eyes at the antics of Goodreads bullies, arguing—quite sensibly!—that people should write whatever they want, read whatever they want, and stop behaving like jerks.

In all likelihood, the variable most responsible for shaping our judgments of books isn't political loyalties, internet algorithms, or regnant cultural narratives, but simple personal taste. People like what they like, and up to a point, that shouldn't cause any consternation. Maybe you prefer the characters and storylines of Dickens to those of Dostoevsky. Maybe you find histories of World War II captivating and histories of the War of 1812 a relative snooze. By and large, such idiosyncrasies don't lend themselves to moral and intellectual scrutiny.

Yet moral and intellectual strictures are unavoidable in any properly Christian account of our relationship to books and reading. Which compels us to reject, on one hand, extremes of pure subjectivism.

Christians can make generous allowances, of course, for quirks of personal taste. Gospel freedom gladly permits an affinity for your favorite pastor's relatable anecdotes, your favorite theologian's illuminating illustrations, or your favorite writer's winning way with words. What it doesn't permit is the easygoing ethos suggested in stereotypes of the modern book club, where people nod along to every utterance with unfailing politeness, never daring to introduce any buzzkill notions of right and wrong.

As with the pulpit, so with the printed page: Venturing claims about God Almighty, maker of heaven and earth, is a serious business, never to be undertaken without a superabundance of fear and trembling. Misrepresenting his Word, works, and ways is no trifling offense! The Bible underscores this point with several sobering cautions. In the Gospels, Jesus presents drowning as a fitting fate for anyone guilty of deceiving his followers (Matt. 18:6; Mark 9:42; Luke 17:2). And the Book of James warns of the stricter judgment in store for anyone wearing the mantle of teacher (3:1).

We can see the danger, then, of adopting a relaxed, read-and-let-read posture when basic biblical fidelity hangs in the balance. But Scripture also abounds with useful guidance for evaluating books lying outside the explicit domains of theology and doctrine.

Consider Paul's exhortation, in Philippians, to dwell upon "whatever is true, whatever is noble, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is admirable" or "excellent" or "praiseworthy" (4:8). Or his contrast, in Ephesians, between "unwholesome talk" and speech that "build[s] others up according to their needs, that it may benefit those who listen" (4:29). And don't forget Proverbs, that redoubtable repository of tutelage on wisdom and folly, which teaches extensively on taming the tongue and weighing our words.

These verses weren't written primarily to help us navigate contemporary bestseller lists. Nor do they furnish some infallible rubric for literary discernment. People, Christians included, will disagree on what counts as praiseworthy, admirable, or wholesome. But making these ideals a compass lifts our reading habits above the realm of individual preference.

So far, I suppose, so uncontroversial. Faithful believers, accustomed to invoking universal truth and biblical authority, seem largely immune to the fiction that all books are created equal. Give us an artistic product, literary or otherwise, and we'll give you a value judgment.

Yet here we confront an opposite extreme that many Christians have a tougher time ruling out: an overconfidence in the possibility of grading every book on objective measures of moral, theological, and spiritual correctness. I believe such measures exist. I simply question whether fallen human beings can apprehend and apply them with wholly uncorrupted hearts and minds.

Sure, there are plenty of open-and-shut cases. I have no qualms, for instance, in commending the works of Tim Keller as better sources of spiritual nourishment than anything rolling off the self-help or New Age presses. But my experience as books editor at *Christianity Today* attests to an element of unpredictability at odds with the oracular pretensions on display among certain raters and rankers.

Case in point: The *CT* Book Awards offers an evangelical riff on the old saw about a room with 10 economists generating 11 opinions. In my role overseeing the awards process, I would recruit panels of judges to evaluate set lists of finalists in theology, apologetics, missions, everyday discipleship, and other major subjects. Almost without fail, their evaluations landed all over the map, even controlling for the presence of figures representing different wings of the evangelical big tent. On a shockingly routine basis, pastors and professors with nearly identical credentials and outlooks arrived at radically different conclusions after reading the very same books.

All this casts doubt on formulas for drawing neat dividing lines between books that are spiritually healthy and spiritually harmful, as though the task merely requires enlisting the right theological criteria or pulling the right levers of worldview analysis. These are indispensable tools, in reading as in all of life. But they won't unlock firsthand access to the mind of Christ, "in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Col. 2:3). Books are less imponderable than the mysteries of redemption, but we behold both only through darkened, clouded lenses.

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Ultimately, the case against a "quality-control" approach to books and reading rests on something deeper than the difficulty of determining which books deserve evangelicalism's seal of approval. It touches on fundamental questions of why we read, and what we hope to gain thereby.

Pardon one further anecdote from my time at *CT*. Over the years, I became something of a squeaky wheel about ending the magazine's convention of attaching a star rating to each book under review. Not only because many reviewers got antsy about appearing overly mean or harsh, ensuring a dynamic not unlike college grade inflation. More importantly, because I wanted readers to grapple with the review in its entirety, rather

than fixating on whether the reviewer "liked" the book. I wanted to train attention on the subtleties and complexities of appreciation and critique, rather than see the whole package compressed into a reductive *yea* or *nay*.

When we read, we do more than offer ourselves as willing receptacles of correct information and wholesome lessons. We exercise God-given gifts of reason and reflection, wrestling with matters of logic and coherence, beauty and profundity, truth and error. In this sense, immersing oneself in a book—following its narrative shape, assessing strengths and weaknesses, pausing to savor flashes of insight or arresting turns of phrase—is inherently enriching. The process is its own reward, irrespective of any judgments reached along the way.

One favorite book of mine, published around the time I began at *CT*, is Alan Jacobs's *The Pleasures of Reading in an Age of Distraction*. In it, he advocates reading books that bring delight, likening an obsessive focus on intellectual self-improvement to schoolmarmish tut-tutting about eating one's vegetables.

Likewise, I've grown convinced that a preoccupation with ratings and seals of approval drains the joy from reading. It flattens our love affair with books into a pedantic quest for a perfected syllabus, with every potential stumbling block mercifully weeded out.

Far better, I think, to picture the world's shelves and stacks as a lush garden or an immense banquet, full of delectable fare. Yes, we need guidance on avoiding thorns and thistles (to say nothing of crafty serpents). Yes, we need reminders to eat some salad before raiding the dessert tray. All of God's gifts come with guardrails. But discerning where they lie shouldn't cast a gloomy shadow over our invitation to taste, see, and read that the Lord is good.



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The Sacred and the Profane

PAUL ELIE. *THE LAST SUPPER: ART, FAITH, SEX, AND CONTROVERSY IN THE 1980S.* FARRAR, STRAUS AND GIROUX, 2025. $33.00. 496 PP.

KIRSTEN SANDERS

Mircea Eliade imagined a world that was split down the middle. On the one side was the sacred—a world of gods and demons, of angels ascending and descending on ladders that just barely touched the earth. On the other side was the profane—the world of bodies forgetful of the origin of their desire, ruminating over causes and cures.

Secular man, regardless of his intent, has not been abandoned by religion. Into the secular frame come hierophanies, those disorienting occasions when the profane—a tree, a rock, a man—become sacred. Israel encounters these, when water comes from a rock or when a donkey speaks God's words to a man. The sacred is apart from the secular, but the door is locked from the inside. God can still enter in, and man can build sacred spaces within the profane, all to be able to access and pay deference to the holy.

Eliade's observation of these two modalities of existence does not mean that the religious is merely a premodern delusion. The opposite, in fact, is true. If religion is dead, to misquote Julian Barnes, we certainly miss it. Our

nostalgia for the God we don't believe in is evident, I suspect, in the ways secular humans seek out transcendence in everything other than God. Sex becomes a medium for engaging the holy, as does childbirth and maternity. Music might be a pathway, as is art, or you could skip the difficulty of artistic production and go right to LSD.

Eliade's interest is in the way man builds monuments to the sacred within the world of the profane. These "sacred spaces" are habitations, places for man to experience the numinous reality of a largely forgotten God.

But besides architecture, there are other places where man might encounter the sacred in a world largely void of it. In his book *The Last Supper: Art, Faith, Sex, and Controversy in the 1980s*, Paul Elie traces the way religious instincts, reminiscences, and longings appeared in the art and music of an era that was rife with such memory. Elie is also the author of *The Life You Save May Be Your Own*, an award-winning narrative account of Dorothy Day, Thomas Merton, Walker Percy, and Flannery O'Connor. Thus he is no stranger to Catholic thinkers. He is a careful narrator and a compelling writer. His new book is a matchless effort to ask a question that many thinkers are asking in a less interesting and more plodding way: How did America get so *secular*?

How America got secular is not Elie's question exactly. Rather, Elie wants to query the in-between time, when the sacred still provoked the imaginations of America's best artists and musicians. Perched on the backend of a religious century but on the brink of an irreligious one, the 1980s was a decade rife with religious referent. The artists Elie writes about are too numerous to list here. They include Andy Warhol, Toni Morrison, Bruce Springsteen and Patti Smith; U2, the Neville Brothers, and Sinead O'Connor; Martin Scorsese, Salman Rushdie, Robert Mapplethorpe, and Madonna, Leonard Cohen and Bob Dylan.

In Elie's hands, the 1980s become a decade throbbing with the awareness of the sacred. He opens with a story of Sinead O'Connor on *Saturday Night Live* in 1992. When she tore a photo of John Paul II and scattered it on the stage, she made herself "a heretic, a public enemy, and unladylike, besides."

O'Connor in Elie's hands, however, is no heretic. She is not even formerly religious. In a term once deployed by Czeslaw Milosz, Elie sees her as *crypto-religious*. Elie believes this describes all of the artists he surveys in the book.

"What's striking in retrospect," he writes,

> "Isn't just that artists are marking reference to religion in their work. It is that they take the religious point of view seriously and personally. They aren't set against religious authority, at least not at first. They aren't anti-religious or irreligious. They're crypto-religious. For them prayer, scripture, image and ritual are material they claim as their own via the imagination and seek to complicate and deepen not to do away with. They forthrightly cite their religious roots; they count themselves as believers and regard their work as the expression of convictions formed through intense self-scrutiny. Seen as faithless or profane, they see themselves and

> their approach to religion as more faithful to the core truths of faith than the clerics and televangelists, and they hope the public will agree…

For the crypto-religious, religion isn't a structure of historic oppression or a bad influence to be opposed on principle. It is inheritance and legacy, underworld and promised land. It's a fact on the ground and a stumbling block. It is what it has been for a broad range of believers all along: a means of making sense of the world and our place in it."

Why, then, not just be religious?

Elie describes the early 1980s as "both an end and a beginning." It was the end of the "long sixties," a term coined by Fredric Jameson in 1984 to describe the end of the era where religion was largely cooperative to public life. Religion was a "moderate center." But in the 1980s, though the "post secular" age had not quite reached the fullness it knows today, religion's decline had begun. The 1980s was the beginning of a questioning that still had belief at its root.

Elie has a delicate hand with the crypto-areligious artists of the 1980s. When he writes of Andy Warhol, who opened a monumental *Last Supper* exhibit in Milan, Elie describes the recounting as a portrait of "a group of men [who have] come together and have a meal in the knowledge that one of them is going to die soon." The relation between the *Last Supper* and the death of scores of gay men in Warhol's orbit can't be missed. In Warhol's hand, the work "became a work of social commentary." Meanwhile, Warhol writes in his journal that he still went to church, still prayed, still found God to be a figure in the world. Religion looms, inspires, and dominates Warhol's artistic imagination.

In Leonard Cohen's work, Elie sees a crypto-religious crypto-monk "in sync with the convergence of art, belief, and desire that is taking place in the city." A descendant of rabbis, Cohen lived as an "unchaste monk." He excelled at unearthing the deep connections between sex and religion, between devotion of the soul and the body's longings. With songs like "If It Be Your Will." "Anthem," and especially "Hallelujah," Cohen "joins religious desire and sexual desire as few songs have done before or since." In the process, "Cohen goes to the outer rim of transcendence where devotion and desire meet and consort together." He is a genius of crypto-religious art.

Elie writes no less compellingly of U2, Prince, Madonna, Aaron Neville; Martin Scorcese, Robert Mapplethorpe, Czeslaw Milosz. In all their art, the world of gods and demons is nigh—the angels ascending and descending close by, just out of sight.

But if religion is so inspiring—if it is indeed the real frame of reference, the truest story about the world—then why are these artists running from, and not toward it?

Two crises befell American religion in the 1980s. Both occurred within Roman Catholicism, which is the context of Elie's religious observations. Both crises in his mind seem to underwrite the widespread flight from religion.

The first was the HIV/ AIDS epidemic.

Initially mistaken for a "gay cancer," the earliest evidence of this disease appeared in 1980s New

York. Its tell-tale symptoms—"blotchy skin, severe weight loss, difficulty breathing"—led inevitably to death. Without consistent treatment or a standard of care, patients, the vast majority of whom were gay men, suffered the physical aspects of the disease as well as the mental and psychological effects of being untreatable: "Gay men showed symptoms, became ill, went to the hospital, died."

Adding to the drama of this terrible illness was the Catholic imagery that loomed over many of the hospitals that treated the sickest men. The Catholic Church was providing care for AIDS patients; St. Vincent's and St. Clare's each had a hospice for people with AIDS. But at the same time John O'Connor, then archbishop of New York, said he would "shut down [the church's] several hundred schools and hospitals if required to employ openly gay people in them." Elie sees this macabre irony visually depicted at St. Vincent's: "There through the window of the emergency room was AIDS in Catholic terms—the gaunt men in the waiting area overseen by the gaunt man who hung on a cross mounted on the wall." The crucifix came to life in ways horrific, terrible, and desperately, undeniably real. Both gaunt men died, and both become for Elie a specter, an image of the Church's lack of mercy.

The second crisis was only whispered of at the time. It was the sexual abuse crisis whose extent would not come to light for years. But already with the trial of Gilbert Gauthe in 1984, the Catholic Church was aware of the pattern of molestation and sexual abuse by priests that occurred within its parishes. Elie suggests that the Church's unwillingness to address the extent of the problem was directly related to the hardening of the church's view on sexuality and contraception.

"At a moment when the bishops had unprecedented power and influence in American public life," he writes:

> "their wish to suppress, deny, explain away, and justify widespread criminal sexual misconduct in their ranks put them on the defensive. It prompted them to turn their energies away from matters of war and peace, of justice and inequality, and onto matters of sexual morality. And it led them to try to manage complex questions of human sexuality rather than ponder them. In effect, the bishops sought to defer and evade the inevitable controversy over sexual misconduct by priests, and the challenge to clerical authority it would bring, by shifting attention onto the sexual conduct of everybody else. And they transferred the fear and anger the controversy aroused in them onto a different controversy- the one involving the Church and people with AIDS."

In what Elie suggests was an intentional sleight of hand, the church focused on legislative documents that outlawed contraception in order to avoid the closer scrutiny that the allegations of sexual abuse in its ranks would have brought. The church's "creeping obsession with sex" led them to reactive stances about sexuality in general instead of addressing the problem in their own hierarchy.

Artists struggle with prohibitions on sex. Sex is, after all, among the most supple subjects for the

production of art. Whatever else it is, sex seems to be an invitation to transcendence—or at least an invitation to whatever is beyond the self. The collision of sex and God is evident throughout Christian history. The early ascetics emphasized denial to avoid temptations. The later mystics mixed thinking of sex and God, emerging with a sort of amalgam of desire and religiosity. Moderns, for the most part, preferred not to speak of sex, or to dismiss its pleasure, delegating it all to the private realm. By the time the "long sixties" had receded with its sexual excesses, what was left was mostly a question mark about the relation between sex and God.

Visual artists like Andy Warhol and Keith Haring emphasized the question of sex and God. Sex was either transgressive or religious; or perhaps seeing sex as religious was the desired transgression. Either way, with blood spattered crucifixes at rock concerts and profane Madonnas; it is easy to assume that art of the 1980s was "anti-religious." This was certainly how the conservative evangelicals of the Moral Majority would prefer Christians think about such spectacles.

But Elie is not so sure. To him, spectacles like blood-soaked crucifixes, sexual entanglements, and couplings were spectacular because they pointed to images that were still heavy with meaning. The blood-spattered Christ spoke to a gory salvation, the heavy breasts of the Madonna were (purportedly) filled with milk to feed God himself. The religion that such artists were nostalgic for might have been lost to them, but the gaps left behind remained. Like empty wounds, the holes that religion had left in secular culture cried out to be filled—and these holes in the secular were filled with art that beckoned to a higher meaning.

For a time, the artists of the 1980s made such art. By Elie's account, this was because religion still existed as a site of transgression. You could still transgress the sacred, because "the sacred" was still very much intact. So when the heights of the AIDS crisis seemed to demand direct action, and the activists of ACT UP chose St. Patrick's Cathedral for the site, the shock that was felt was intended. The Cathedral was still holy enough to the everyman to be transgressed.

The goal of the ACT UP protest, which serves as the cover art for Elie's book, was to force the government to commit to greater AIDS research, as well as to get the Church hierarchy's attention. The U.S. Bishops of the Catholic church had issued a recent letter condemning condom use and emphasized the appropriateness of sex only within the context of marriage and conception. But the letter seemed to ignore the public health crisis of HIV. The Church's insistence that it was the "expert on humanity," while seemingly ignoring the very human crisis happening under its watch, made the choice of a church for a direct action protest seem the most fitting place for the desired confrontation. When an activist took the Eucharist, broke it, and scattered it all over the cathedral floor, the images shocked the country. By violating the sacred space of a cathedral, the activists had ignored the line between religious observance and secular protest.

There is a way to read this activism as a shattering, as the crossing of a Rubicon. The intent of the protest was to resist the Church's stated hegemony on matters of humanity and human sexuality, and to force the government's hand to come to the aid of those suffering the effects of HIV/AIDs.

But certainly, an unintended effect was to desecrate the last place where the sacred had the upper hand. When they lay down and played dead in the cathedral, the activists made a religious shelter a place of political theatre. They contested the Church's claims to bearing the ultimate truth about the world. Their site of resistance, the collapse of the Church's authority, became the reality of the world that was yet to come.

If there is a hero of Elie's book, we only meet him halfway through. He is the Franciscan friar Mychal Judge—a gay man, a recovering alcoholic, and a Franciscan. He placed ads in the gay newspapers of New York, advertising himself "In the spirit of Francis of Assisi… serving our brothers and sisters with AIDS." The church where he lived, the Church of St. Francis of Assisi, was "an outpost for gay Catholics," with Judge running a ministry for people with AIDS.

He visited people in their apartments and in hospitals, "four people in a typical day." He would massage their feet or hear their confessions. He prayed with them and anointed them with oil. "He organized their wakes, celebrated their funeral Masses, saw to the final disposition of their bodies." Elie writes of Judge: "He was not openly gay, and not an unstinting advocate for the rights of gay people in the Church." He was himself a contradiction. But he knew that the Church was a place of mercy.

As the HIV/AIDs crisis overlapped with the sexual abuse crisis, the decisions of activists to desecrate places of worship hardened the division between church and world. When the Catholic Church chose to speak to ideal human norms instead of lived human suffering, the overlapping realities of humanity, both sides hardened. We live now in the aftermath of this hardening.

But what Judge reveals—the Franciscan man, poor in spirit in more ways than one—is that the church's face is, and has always been, mercy. To cradle the feet of dying men was a mercy. And to remain with the Catholic Church, even as a contradiction, Judge chose mercy.

The 1980s were rife with the dissolution of the sacred. Boundary-transgressing artists were ready to spill blood, to sing of prolific sex and to push the boundaries of sexual norms. Placed against the images of the AIDs crisis, the "gay plague," it seemed the world might implode. It would be easy to assume that this was *the* crisis, the battle between sacred and secular, between holy and profane, between life and death.

But meanwhile, quietly and close at hand, were Judge and others like him, quietly anointing foreheads with oil, tenderly massaging feet. Mychal Judge did all of this until his own final moment. When the Twin Towers fell on September 11, 2001, he rushed to the site. He entered the North Tower, where he offered prayers and aid for the rescuers and the dead. He was killed when the South Tower collapsed.

Religion walks the borderline like this, between life and death, marking in its presence the space between holy and profane. To map it is to be open to surprise, to see where you've been wrong, to touch and be touched with oil, with water, with the relief that comes from being received. Religion itself reveals the crisis, as it makes demands on our allegiances. God stands in the just-beyond.

The artists that Elie writes of longed for the God they didn't believe in. Each in different ways, they referenced the God of the Catholicism they had left behind, longing for its order, structure. They longed most of all for the mystery that referred beyond themselves, beyond the violence of death and suffering—and most of all for the mystery *beyond*. They wanted to know that the cathedrals of the city were still there, offering a window to this beyond, even if they were empty and even if they themselves never went.

If the world is indeed split down the middle with angels and demons on one side and the profane on the other, there are yet cracks. There are small openings, tributaries that run from one side to the other. The bridge between the two worlds, the cracks in the fissure, the tributary that carries one from religion to the beyond—it is mercy.

The artists Elie writes of didn't believe in God, but they sure as hell missed him. I do believe in God, but when I am in church, I sometimes miss him too. I search as they did, in art, in music, in the desire of the body, in the faces of the suffering. When I miss God, it is mercy that I miss the most.

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LUCKY TO BE GRATEFUL

WENDELL BERRY. *MARCE CATLETT: THE FORCE OF A STORY.*
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ELISABETH LASCH-QUINN

We are the lucky ones. One can only imagine the near-infinity of invocations of this thought over human history. How many people are even saying or thinking it in the very moment in which I write this thought—or you read it? Whether for those uttering the sentiment or those hearing it expressed, an inevitable addendum follows: Why? Lucky. . . how so? Lucky. . .for what?

The outpouring of thoughts we have from Wendell Berry—in the form of poetry, essays, and fiction—is nothing if not a sustained answer to this question. This sometimes surfaces subtly when he launches his most trenchant criticism of the industrialization, mechanization, and environmental destruction wrought by modern economic, technological, and demographic developments, for instance in his now classic work, *Unsettling of America: Culture & Agriculture*. But in many of his poems and fiction, it hits the reader over the head—in a good way. In *Marce Catlett: The Force of a Story*, the latest in his series of Port William novels, the answer comes, true to its title, in the form of a story.

The story at the heart of the novel takes place long before the life of its protagonist, Andy Catlett. Readers learn the story in question through the gripping first 31 pages titled simply "The Past." In 1906, after the year of hard work to bring their tobacco crop from seed to harvest, Andy's grandfather and a neighbor friend rode their horses in the dark to catch the train to Louisville to sell it, only to find it was worth not just nothing, but even less. A single wealthy buyer caused prices to fall so low that the price offered was less than it took to produce the crop and transport it to market. So the story follows Marce (short for Marcellus) back home with nothing to show for his labor, and nothing to add to a household economy already stretched to the breaking point, riven with debt since the 1890s. His wife had said to him the night before the midnight ride, that whatever amount of money they received, "we'll be glad of it, because we *need* it." When her husband told her upon returning from Louisville that they

had not received a cent, "she was silent." Told from the point of view of their youngest son, old enough to feel his mother's pain if too young to grasp its cause, "Wheeler would remember the fear in his mother's silence. He would remember it as the silence of justice outraged and hopeless. But on that night he was able to know only that she meant her silence to conceal her suffering."

This novel, centering on one of the families that appear frequently in the Port William novels, the Catletts, goes on to detail story after story that spins off from that momentous ride through the darkness of the wee hours of night. If one were to read chronologically for plot alone, Wheeler's participation, once grown, in founding "an organization of farmers that for the six decades of its political life gave them an asking price for their tobacco crops," the Burley Tobacco Growers Co-operative Association, would stand out. So would what we encounter as Andy's "homecoming," when he left the "good living" he had achieved for himself, his wife Flora, and two children, by writing for a farming magazine in Chicago, to move his family back to the Catlett family's neighborhood in Port William. This is because, in addition to these and the other stories relayed in the book is an overarching story all its own, of the larger historical change of which their lives were a part. This latter story casts a kind of shadow over the stories of the individuals and families, a story of that very way of life that Wheeler defended and to which Andy intended to return but which he found changing beyond recognition as machines and agricultural consolidation displaced small farmers, their communities, and customs. The book joins Berry's other works in comprising an elegy for such a life gone by.

Yet to see Berry mainly an elegist would be to miss the unruly way he tells his stories, whether of Marce, Wheeler, Andy and the other Catletts, the other individuals and families in their neighborhood, or the world they were born into and saw vanishing. After the careful narration of each step in order of Marce's disastrous trek to market and back in the past comes a longer portion of the book, "The Future." It is as if, in the playing out of the original story, all sense of linear time is let go.

It is true we find out what happened to main characters such as Wheeler and Andy, but embarking on each of the fifteen brief chapters and the even smaller episodes into which they are divided, it is never clear where we will find ourselves in time. In Chapter I, we find that "Andy Catlett has grown now into the old age of a grandson, son, father, and grandfather." We then hear the story of Andy's father as a young and middle-aged man, of Wheeler's wild brother, Andrew, who died young in a fight he provoked, and by chapter VI, we are back in Andy's childhood, encountering a different side of Marce's wife Dorie, Andy's grandmother, "who often made a companion of him." Faded by her silent worry into the background of Marce's original tale, she now comes to life in vivid detail. Andy accompanies her as she hoes in the garden, tends chickens and turkeys, and more: "She could milk a cow if she needed to, as Andy discovered to his shame when he neglected his chores. When the milk came to the house from the barn, she strained it into crocks, set the crocks in the cellar to cool, skimmed off the cream when it rose, churned the cream into butter, and shaped the butter into pats of about a pound apiece, which she ornamented by crisscrossing their tops with the edge of the butter paddle." Although

Andy grasped that his grandparents did not get along and that "his grandma was not a happy woman," after Marce dies Andy discovers that she has kept a corsage from their 50th wedding anniversary the year before. Andy felt his grandmother's grief at the loss of her son "as something dreadful and permanent" and her sorrow at the loss of her husband. In Chapter VII we find Marce alive again, as we see him, in turn, through Andy's eyes.

And so the story proceeds, each step forward necessitating yet another leap backward, jumping back up to the present then edging forward into a future unforeseen, perhaps, but not entirely unexpected. As the stories unfold, then fold back upon themselves, then fold forward at an angle, the trajectory is toward inevitable loss. When Andy feels—or rather, lives—the mourning of his grandmother, "he learned of grief by signs that he would understand only later, as his own years and griefs accumulated." He moves his family back to rural Kentucky only to find the culture of small farms vanishing. On the larger scale of change, "the traditional subsistence economies of households and neighborhoods were supplanted by the global economy of extraction, consumption, and waste," while on the smaller scale, people left the countryside to earn for "purchasing power" in the consumer economy in place the skill and self-sufficiency of "homemade goods" and "handwork."

Berry makes it clear through this fictional account of real-world developments that he believes this was a change of epic proportions: a clear and unmitigated tragedy. Not only that, he makes it clear that for Andy, as well as his father and grandfather, it was experienced as a personal failure not to see their lives of stewardship result in a continuation of these locally rooted manners and mores: "Andy has come at last to see his grandfather Catlett, his father, and himself as three aged brothers made so by their shared vision of a life permanently settled in a place chosen and beloved, but made brothers also by their failure: their discovery that the vision, as each one of them in his own time has seen it, could not live beyond them, so hard upon them has been the force of the changing times."

In passages of synthesis, it becomes clear what the organizing principle of the novel really is. It clearly follows the pathways of memory, as Andy reflects, very late in life by the time the narrative begins, on his entire life history, the people in it, and its ultimate significance. Yet even more than that, it follows the path of a certain kind of memory. It is not stream-of-consciousness, even though it has Proustian elements, with exquisite details such as the smell of an old, dried carnation, whose color had faded, still able to flood young Andy's senses upon opening the drawer. It is the path of a well-exercised muscle of memory always reaching for understanding.

This memory-for-understanding—a very different faculty from idle meanderings or ransackings for fleeting entertainment—explains the capaciousness of the narrative, which runs back and forth over a huge swath of time, breaking beyond the bounds of a single human life include both those who came before and those yet to come. As Andy's strength fades in old age, and he could not work the land anymore, "he began to waken into his memory and the memory of his elders." Berry's stirring prose then evokes that most momentous of reasons Andy has for this awakening

in his heightened awareness of death. He continues, "It was as if his soul had learned so to speak, to stand outside his own life in the great opening in which time comes and goes, in the company and council of fellow souls." Now the linear narration and episodic skipping of stones over the rippling surface of time past, present, and future both seem to give way to a soaring timelessness as Andy pulls away from the historical particulars: "In reveries and dreams he makes his way among loved ones lost to one another in this world's great sundering, as if again in their presence and present to them, as if in some hereafter already here."

So Berry's answer to the question of why we are the lucky ones—why in his rendering, Andy still comes across as believing himself one of the lucky ones, despite the very real disasters he recounts with such poignancy—is found here near the end. It is not in spite of the devastation of the land and the folkways it sustained that Andy finds solace, or in spite of the losses and injuries sustained in the course of his life. It is through them. Wave upon wave of understanding over the course of remembering a life and a particular story as it played out in multiple lives ended not in bitterness—though it had a share of that, too—but in a breathless invocation of a devastated country, "continuing by the spirit and the breath of God toward whatever in God's time it is coming to."

In a final image, Andy describes in loving detail the unexpected beauty of the sunken cellar that "provided Grandma Catlett a place to store her canned goods, and in the warm months to set her crocks of fresh milk, morning and evening, to wait for the cream to rise." Even in the sorrow of the razing of the dome of this storage room that so enchanted Andy as a boy, we learn that its beauty—though "not as evident as that of a vault or dome in a church"—inspires reverence. No matter our suffering, we are lucky to know such people and the reverence-worthy places—these everyday cathedrals—they construct and inhabit.

We usually hear the phrasing that we are grateful to be lucky in some way. But Berry turns this thought around in this book as in his work overall: we are lucky to be grateful. "As he has come to know, Andy's grief for the things that are lost affirms his love for them, as even the loss of them affirms the bounty by which they once existed, for in this world grief goes hand in hand with gratitude." If we lose—somethings, someplace, someone—we love with all the passion that is humanly possible. We are the lucky ones. Even our agony, if we cultivate, as few have taught us to do as well as Berry, our memory-for-understanding, we enter the realm of love, which knows everything of pain but nothing of change.



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A Passage Through the Dark

WENDELL BERRY. *MARCE CATLETT: THE FORCE OF A STORY.*
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KATY CARL

The acknowledgment of failure is the fertile ground of humility from which new growth may spring. That acknowledgment lies at the heart of Wendell Berry's most recent and possibly final Port William novel, *Marce Catlett: The Force of a Story*. Failure must also be a major preoccupation of this essay, which is more meditation than review—*Marce Catlett* and with it the whole Port William oeuvre being the kind of text that evaluates you rather than the other way around. Much that might otherwise have been obscure becomes clear under the gentle but unyielding gaze of Berry's newest tale, this tale that, it ought to be said, more fluently unites Berry the fictionist and Berry the essayist than perhaps any of his works that have come before it.

At the heart of Berry's well-known agrarian ethic dwells the same question meditating upon which had led John Crowe Ransom to renounce a once-thoroughgoing agrarianism by 1945: "the unhappy human condition that has arisen under the modern economy, and whether art and religion can do anything about it." Ransom turned from believing that renewal was only possible within a revival of rural life to an embrace of the goods only towns and cities can generate and sustain. Berry begs to differ, holding fast to the conviction that only a closer relationship with the land can possibly revive a vital creativity and generativity in human culture. Berry also advocates for an insistence on the practice of not just conservation of resources—not just the platitudes of reduction, reuse, and recycling—but a specific type of active cultivation of the earth and its fruits that most urban dwellers will never have the background, skills, experience, or opportunity to practice.

This agrarian ideal is so demanding, so rigorous, so all-consuming, that even those who give the entirety of their lives and attention to it are likely to fall short of its desirable completion. Dilettantes cannot hope to succeed here; weekend warriors need not apply. This may be one of the major reasons why, though the ethos is commonplace, the practice has failed to take root. As John Crowe Ransom also wrote, in an observation to which my own exurban existence can't help but consent:

> "without consenting to division of labor, and hence modern society, we should have not only no effective science, invention, and scholarship, but nothing to speak of in art … The arts are the expiations [of science's unintended consequences], but they are beautiful. … They seem worth the vile welter through which homeless spirits must wade between times, with sensibilities subject to ravage as they are. On these terms the generic human economy can operate, and they are the only terms practicable now."

Most Americans, living on these terms—in debt or in thrall to market forces, in suburbs or in high-rises, dashing from here to there on the dubious vapors of fossil fuel—will never be the kinds of localist or the kinds of cultivator that Berry's ethic considers most admirable.

The near-total absence of the city, *any* city, in the good life of Berry's imagination is notable. Only one major Port William denizen, Wheeler Catlett, seems to have any place or meaningful relation within the human city as such, the *polis* (it is perhaps not part of this ideal, or idyll, to recognize that the city is also a natural form of human social organization). Whatever happens in urbanity is, in this ideal, ordered only toward Wheeler's ability to escape once again into fields of bluegrass and tobacco and help those fields flourish. The specter of a management job in Chicago is raised as though it were the serpent's offer of the apple to Eve, and as briskly and summarily rejected as we might wish Eve had done the apple.

But in order for Berry's vision to be anything like realized, even one-tenth realized, there will have to be many, many more people who admit the influence, even, yes, the force of Marce Catlett's story

yet who do not closely recapitulate the conditions of Marce's life: not only a veritable army of Wheeler Catletts, but many hundreds of Thomas Franklins, that is principled and ethical lawmakers in public office; many thousands, too, of high-minded and principled staffers to keep the work of that army of Thomas Franklins going; many, many more who are decently resourced and honored for the good work of *oikonomoi* that silently underlies anyone's capacity to live any kind of human life, whether in city, town, or country: in short, many more denizens who by their ways of life and their commitments do not devalue but rather honor the Marce Catletts of the world on whose dedication their own capacity for dedication reciprocally depends. There will even have to be many who take on those oh so tempting and apparently so fraught management jobs, who buy and sell the commodities the abundant fields produce, who are able to consider and receive their work not as temptation but as blessing; many who look out their windows not at bluegrass but at steel and concrete, and yet who keep something of the garden alive in mind and in practice, even if only on a rooftop or a balcony.

While "apple" language may be perfectly apt as a metaphor to explore the undeniable evils of modernity, this more concrete presentation of diminished goods in the city, Berry's implicit weighting of urbanity as the more deprived and more circumscribed of two possible modes of life, will and should trouble the thoughts of even the most committed city dweller. Before this novel's candid face the reader becomes keenly aware of both the limitations and the urgent necessity of all human prudence. If we are hesitant in the face of such passionate and convicted statements about the ethical as Berry finds necessary, perhaps it is often because we are too conscious (defensive? afraid of deep self-examination?) when it comes to the contradictions inherent in our own habits and practices. Both the healthy rural and the healthy urban are, if not declining, at least shifting shape dramatically under our eyes and hands daily.

Berry's narrator and authorial scout Andy Catlett, an experienced observer of these shifts as they have played out under his own eyes and hands over the course of many decades, is as trustworthy a fictional voice as we are likely to find, so closely does his experience recapitulate what we may surmise to have been Berry's own. In this story more urgently than anywhere before, he is as candid as can be with his children and grandchildren, who are the implicit listeners to his tale: The hope of having a home place rooted in the land, sustainable, independent, beholden only to its own people and its own standards without needing or wanting to turn elsewhere, is an ideal that has largely failed so far in America. We could look at history and argue that the ideal has also failed, to some extent, in some ways, as long as humans have farmed. That human success and human failure are somehow joined at the root. That all our successes seem to involve and include failures, sometimes catastrophic ones. That, most important, to succeed at some things might be to fail at others.

Please understand that this is anything but glib language play: it is an attempt to dig in deeper to the unavoidable ethical question, *How should we commit our lives?* And perhaps, to some extent,

even: *What must we do to be saved?*

Part of the force of Marce Catlett's story is a championing of precisely the specialist's value to any socioeconomic fabric. His tobacco farmers of the recent past are specialists *par excellence*, even artists of a kind. What, then, seems to be missing from the picture? It is certainly not tenderness for those workers who nourish and nurture the world, nor gratitude for the gifts of abundance that flow through their hands. It may be, again, a sensibility about the value of the city itself. What end, after all, were all those beautifully grown and layered hands of tobacco, packed so delicately into hogshead barrels, destined *for*? Is it really such a horror and a harm that town and country should be interdependent, ultimately all part of the same irreducible membership of the human? "Though you deal in messages from heaven, the whole curse of trade attaches to the business," wrote Thoreau: and the "curse of trade" with which *Marce Catlett* is preoccupied seems to describe, also, a curse *upon* those who trade and upon those who consume without proportionately producing.

In turn, this observation lives too close for comfort to a feeling awfully common in capitalist societies (whatever else you may think about such societies): the feeling that what one merits is exactly and only what one *earns*, in the strictest and basest terms, where the arbiters of who earns what are judging value by an obscure calculus that is never articulated and seems to be constantly shifting. I am surprised by how rarely anyone seems to connect the dots between these rotten roots and their psychological bad fruits. And while self-esteem is radically overrated, healthy self-regard is not, and one striking thing about Berry's characters is how they never seem to lack that regard, which has its roots in the quality of their work.

What Berry, through Catlett, grieves is that the beloved community, Port William, has failed "to value itself at the rate of its affection for itself." This rate was once rooted in the inherent dignity of each person and the inherent quality and satisfaction of good work done for its own sake. Now, instead, American rural places at scale seem to have adopted the devalued self-perception, imposed by a cursed monetary economy, of the small town as "a 'nowhere place,' a place at the end of the wrong direction." This move the poet Patrick Kavanagh would identify as "provincialism," or self-definition through the eyes of the nearby metropolis, as opposed to Kavanagh's positive sense of "parochialism," or an affirmation of the validity of local perception. (The curse of the monetary valuation may also underpin Allen Tate's devil's-dictionary definition of globalism as "world provincialism," meaning, almost surely, "provincial" in Kavanagh's salty sense.) Berry's Port William, in the history told in its earlier iterations, appears as parochial in the best possible, Kavanaghian sense. This is one of the Port William cycle's most compelling aspects for any reader who would like to love his or her place, be that place rural or urban, and to think and act more clearly from the foundation of what the flourishing of *that* place requires.

There is also a gift here for any reader who has given decades to the development and flowering of a humane art some say is dying. This is the novel's

portrayal of farming as craft, tragically overtaken by machine, which serves as a subtle analogy for literature as craft, which is now likewise under threat of being overtaken by machine. Berry celebrates farming as not mere formula—nitrogen in, calories or health benefits out, as swiftly and mechanically as possible, impatient even of the sun's rise and fall—but as a beautiful and cooperative human practice with goods both intrinsic and extrinsic that generate and sustain community around the practice itself.

The analogy packs all the more power because Berry's narrator does not call overt attention to the likeness between the tobacco farming of the early twentieth century and the literary practice of the late twentieth, both of which Berry experienced but only one of which he finds himself in his last years rhapsodizing about. The analogy nevertheless becomes obvious in the painstaking account of the long labor involved in each crop, a labor like that which underlies the making of any good novel (or any other work of art). The closest Berry comes to spelling it out is in telling us that "No painter could have had a more schooled and unresting eye for detail than the farmer who had earned the rank of 'tobacco man,' a title not easily earned and always spoken with respect." There is an artistry in doing this work well, a command of many interlocking skills and a coordination of many individuals' gifts and abilities, whose mastery is little short of prudence itself.

In the age of machine "learning," we desperately need to find a way to preserve and pass on the skills of literate culture. We need to realize that if we do not do so, these skills are as much at risk of being lost as the arts of tobacco growing, harvesting, drying, stripping, and packing—but at much greater cost, and at much greater loss. The devastation of local economies after the end of tobacco farming only faintly presages what stands to be destroyed if we forget ourselves so far as to stop reading, writing, thinking, speaking, and questioning well. This bears more than a little further thinking about; it is a need worthy of spending one's entire life trying to meet.

How might societies better make room for the humane practices that educate, form, and unite? How might we concern ourselves less with quantity and more with quality in our economies and communities, so as to make room for those goods that both encompass and go beyond the merely productive? How might we care equally about the things we make and about the kinds of people we become in and through the making of them? The risk of failure at this life-defining task lies heavy on so many hearts. We may be tempted to say, with Houston ground control during the Apollo missions, that "failure is not an option." But the conditions of the future may not be in our control. If, then, we must not reckon without the reversals of history, how much more must we not reckon without the goodness of Providence?

The total effect of this novel's ethos, implied by the choice of the word *force* (not something violent but something gravitational, almost impersonal), is to give us strength for our own no doubt imminent passages through the dark. It speaks the language of Rilke's archaic torso: *You must change your life*. It

resonates with an observation already made by W.P. Southard in a meditation on Robert Penn Warren's poetry:

> "… maybe the best thing we could do is try to get a seed or two planted, to be available when the world is old enough to want it. It might be enough of piety, enough of love of God, to use your blood up slowly, at an unheroic enterprise, without much confidence. Somewhere between the furious abstract life and the furious classical structures—just a little concrete life, to attach your 'ontological fury' to."

But in what that perennial planting, that concrete life can consist, when so many of us are already mired in so many and such heavy forces that may feel as if they suppress our ability to withstand them, will be the burning question with which most readers will come away, this reader not excepted.

Most of all we must ask: Can the force of a story, transformed by human will from sentiment to action, outdo money, power, and the presence or absence, equally spectral, of enough resources to fuel our needs and desires? Can story outdo wrongheaded calculation, outdo political machination, outdo ideological influence, all to awaken and regenerate the human capacity to choose the good? We have little choice but to hope that it may, though we have considered (or have we?) all the facts.



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Creating Membership

WENDELL BERRY. *MARCE CATLETT: THE FORCE OF A STORY.*
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JAKE MEADOR

In the days leading up to the Blitz in England during World War II, British politicians did what I think we would expect them to do: They braced for the breakdown of society as the stress of Germany's bombing campaigns on London destroyed the structures that make day-to-day life stable and tolerable. What they found, instead, was that severe mental illness seemed to decline significantly during the Blitz. And though surprising, this is far from the only example of this phenomenon. When population groups respond to disaster by displaying greater cohesion and willingness to sacrifice, diminished rates of despair and withdrawal are the natural result.

Journalist Sebastian Junger has written *Tribe* to explain why that happens. Junger suggests that this is because human communities become stronger and more coherent when they face a collective threat that forces them to mobilize together in order to survive. *Tribe* is full of arguments and supporting evidence for this thesis.

The work of Wendell Berry intersects with Junger in odd and interesting ways. One line of thought that

Junger flirts with but that is taken up more fully by figures like Daniel Quinn in his *Ishmael* books and James C. Scott in *Against the Grain* is that the specific erosion of communal life tends to coincide with the adoption of agriculture by a society.

Though he doesn't make this *exact* claim, you could see a very similar argument in parts of Willie James Jennings's book *The Christian Imagination* in his discussion of how pre-modern societies in certain parts of the world enjoy a knowledge of their local place that is unimaginable to anyone living in modern society. According to these authors, hunter-gatherer societies, due to their extreme precarity, tend to have remarkably thick social connection amongst members along with deep knowledge of their place, all of which contribute to a deep feeling of being at home within one's life.

This is what makes Berry's work such an interesting conversation partner for these thinkers, particularly his latest novel *Marce Catlett: The Force of a Story*. As other reviewers have already noted, the "novel" in this case is semi-autobiographical since Andy Catlett is the obvious stand-in for Berry in the fictional world of Port William and Marce is Andy's grandfather, who himself has a striking resemblance to Berry's own grandfather. (Wheeler Catlett, Marce's son and Andy's father, also has many resemblances to Berry's father, John Berry.) *Marce Catlett* is also the least plot-driven of any of Berry's novels, focusing much more on largely forgotten social norms that Marce gave his life to building and that Andy was able to observe in his early years. The primary concern of *Marce Catlett* is the Burley tobacco program that operated in Kentucky for many decades, creating a stable system that insured farmers received a fair rate for their harvest each year, making it easier for families to stay in farming and for small farming communities to maintain their life.

The existence of that program suggests something interesting that directly challenges the arguments of Junger and others like him. For Junger, social cohesion is found in the forced precarity of pre-modern life. The challenge for us today is how to find ways of enduring and mitigating the inevitable damage to common life brought about by our abandonment of tribal life, which is the effect of certain technological changes, starting with agriculture. Politics, then, is basically the art of damage control: How do we structure our life together to mitigate the irreparable social damage caused by technological innovation? Politics might be thought of as a defensive framework for holding back dystopia and despair. In this understanding, the cost of material comfort and technological innovation is eventual social collapse, and the task of politics is to reduce the scale of that breakdown.

Berry dissents from this view in a way that is distinctly Christian, even if Berry himself doesn't take this line of thought as far as he might. Beneath Junger's line of thought is an implicit claim that humans will not form thick communal bonds unless material circumstance forces it upon us. This is the human tragedy: The things that make

individual life more secure and stable tend to tear down communal life. Thus there is an inverse relationship between healthy communal bonds and private material security. This is where Berry–and many in the Christian tradition–dissent.

To get to the point most directly, consider the work of the 17th-century political theorist Johannes Althusius. In the opening pages of his primary political treatise, Althusius makes the claim that political society exists for the sake of making the social relations that cannot be avoided into something mutually beneficial and delightful.

The argument is something like this: There is no way for individual people to subsist in the world entirely through the strength of their own work. We eat food we did not grow, wear clothing made from materials we did not harvest or process, and live in homes we did not build. Americans, perhaps, should be especially understanding of this argument, given our nation's own attempts to refute Althusius: One need only read something like *O Pioneers* to recognize that Althusius is correct, as seen in the collapses into madness or economic failure that were so common on the American frontier when people genuinely did try to live entirely from their own labor. We can't live without each other.

And yet often these unavoidable relationships are also unjust–one side of the relationship finds a way to exploit or abuse the other, thereby profiting from their neighbor's suffering. This is the problem politics attempts to solve, according to Althusius. Because all members of political society are bound by the natural law, which is summarized most neatly in the command to love God and love neighbor, all members of a society should seek to order their relationships together to be beneficial to one another rather than being parasitic or exploitative.

For Christians, then, human beings are inherently social creatures, which means there is no such thing as a non-political life or a life where we do not need politics. Politics is simply what we do. Christian politics are politics that recognize this fact and discern how to structure our social relationships to make them mutually beneficial.

The Burley tobacco program so beloved by Berry and central to the story of *Marce Catlett* is best understood, then, as a model of Christian political wisdom. It was a synthetic project designed and sustained by human endeavor that ensured that all parties in a given relationship benefitted from the work produced by that relationship. In other words, it demonstrates that social cohesion is not *exclusively* a product of material precarity that *forces* people together. Social cohesion can also be created when people determine to pursue each other's good in common and structure their relationships in ways that are mutually uplifting. (We will have to set aside the fact that in this particular case the consumers of the crop actually did not benefit due to the dangers of smoking. That point matters, but it is incidental to the

argument, since one could just as well construct a program like the tobacco program that supported other, healthier crops.)

Though that argument might seem trivial to people steeped in centuries of democratic life in which this idea can be so taken for granted that its distinctiveness is almost forgotten, it is actually quite profound. At the heart of democratic liberalism is a willingness to live with imperfect political outcomes, provided we are able to (likewise imperfectly) structure our relationships to be mutually beneficial to a certain degree. Democratic systems by their very nature accept that lifting up every voice means that some political goods cannot be pursued since they would come at the cost of justice by depriving some people of what they are due in order to give others more than they need.

It is for this reason, of course, that the bonds of democratic liberalism must be renewed in each generation. For the agreements and norms and institutions that sustain our life together are under constant threat. Sometimes it takes tragedy to remind us that we need one another and to force us to act accordingly. Acknowledging this should not turn us into a kind of Jungerian fatalist about the possibilities for common life, however. Rather, it should turn us into civically engaged Christians who see the possibilities for common life, if we are willing to pursue it and think with wisdom and discretion about how to best realize the possible goods set before us. *Marce Catlett* shows us that such endeavors are possible, if only we will allow ourselves to be captured by the force of good stories that show us the way.



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Christians in the Age of Hitler

ALEC RYRIE. *THE AGE OF HITLER AND HOW WE WILL SURVIVE IT.* UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO PRESS, 2025. $24.00. 160 PP.

CHRISTOPHER GEHRZ

Next summer I'll be taking a group on a tour of England, France, and Germany, showing them a few of the myriad sites where World War II was caused, waged, and remembered. We'll stand where soldiers fought on the beaches of Dunkirk and Normandy. We'll imagine total war as civilians suffered it in the streets of London and Paris. And we'll go from National Socialism's birth sites in Munich to its first concentration camp in nearby Dachau and the Nuremberg courtroom where Nazi leaders were convicted of crimes against humanity.

This tour will be something like a modern pilgrimage, if British historian Alec Ryrie is right that "our culture's true religion" is the Second World War, a faith centered not on the positive moral example of Jesus Christ but the negative one of Adolf Hitler. "Perhaps we still believe that Jesus is good," Ryrie allows, "but not with the same fervour and conviction that we believe Nazism is evil."

Except that those of us on this trip, mostly employees or alumni of a Christian university, do believe in Jesus' goodness at least as fervently as we do in Hitler's depravity. So does Ryrie, who is both a historian of

the Protestant Reformation and a lay minister in the Church of England. The tour I am leading will begin with Sunday morning worship at St Paul's Cathedral, near the memorial to London firefighters who died during the Blitz, and end at one of the four religious sites at the north end of the Dachau memorial site. We'll pass under an iron crown of thorns into the Mortal Agony of Christ Chapel, to contemplate the sacrifice of Jesus that inspired the hundreds of Catholic priests martyred at Dachau.

Before I turn in earnest to Ryrie's work, I ought first to acknowledge that I am not the intended audience for *The Age of Hitler*. It's still the story of Jesus that I find to be the greatest ever told, even if no *secular* "narratives other than tales of the Second World War affect me in *quite* the same way." Unlike the generic Anglophone Westerner to whom Ryrie is addressing this book, I haven't "cast off [religion] like a worn-out garment" nor participated in modernity's "wider alienation from Christian ethics." While Ryrie isn't wrong that the post-World War II ethical consensus is fraying, my frequent encounters with that terrible conflict—as a writer, reader, teacher, tour guide, filmgoer, and a veteran's grandson—keep reaffirming for me its lessons about the seemingly bottomless depths of human sinfulness and the importance of striving for human equality and human rights.

I suspect that the same is true for many readers of this journal. Yet I still recommend *The Age of Hitler* for three reasons. First, Ryrie holds "up a mirror to our own age at a particular angle" that reveals how our "deep convictions about justice and human rights" emerged from the wreckage of history's worst war. Second, he helps those of us who still hold those convictions to recognize the limitations of the anti-Nazi ethical consensus and the reasons that it is weakening. Third, Ryrie suggests how moving past the "Age of Hitler" could bring cultural synthesis rather than culture war—a process in which Christians like you and me might well play a catalytic role.

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Those of us who see the crucifix on the altar of Dachau's Catholic chapel and ponder the mystery of the atonement may be unmoved by Ryrie's opening narration of the Christian West entering the twentieth century. Its vaguely religious ethic was centered on the Jesus whose personal example appealed to skeptics like Bertrand Russell, not the Christ who rose from the dead to reign as Lord and will return one day in judgment. But World War II ushered in a new consensus oriented not so much in imitation of the humility, simplicity, and wisdom so widely admired in Jesus as in rejection of the hatred, cruelty, and injustice embodied in Adolf Hitler and his disciples.

"The Western world's encounter with Nazism and its atrocities," explains Ryrie, "triggered what we can only call an ethical reawakening." The postwar ethic centered on the principles articulated in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) in 1948, which asserts that the natural rights inherent to being human offer the surest "foundation of freedom, justice and peace in the world." While Mohandas Gandhi tried to convince the framers of the UDHR that all rights are accompanied by social duties, individual autonomy has joined equality and empathy in making up "the sea in which, during the age of Hitler, we have all been swimming."

Given how Ryrie describes the post-WWII ethic as succeeding a Christian one, it may be surprising to read him admit later that "the new prominence of gay and transgender rights… is one of the few really direct clashes between our societies' older, Christian-based moral norms and our newer, anti-Nazi ones." But even if there is a basic congruence between ethics before and after Hitler, Ryrie argues that contemporary Western values are not timeless or universal but historically contingent: "...we cannot imagine our modern faith in human rights without the experience of the Second World War, and without the understanding of what evil is that came out of that war" — namely, the "grey inhumanity, teetering on the edge of nothingness" found in Hannah Arendt's notion of an evil that was at once radical and banal. If anything, the most atrocious crimes of the Nazis have become even more central to how we tell the story of WWII, particularly in recent movies like *Inglourious Basterds, Fury,* and Holocaust films going back to *Schindler's List*. Meanwhile, "generations of children in the post-Christian West have been raised" on stories of "fictional Hitlers" in *Lord of the Rings*, *Star Wars*, and the Harry Potter series, "cleansing the brutal lessons of the Second World War and transposing them into timeless morality tales."

"We are not, unlike some of our great-grandparents, liable to believe soft-focus nonsense about inherent human innocence," Ryrie concludes. "We have not only seen what people *can* do, we believe that these are things that people *will* do, given half a chance." That's the lesson my students typically take away from our discussion of *Ordinary Men*, Christopher Browning's famous study of German military police who executed hundreds of Polish Jews and deported thousands more to Treblinka not because they were fanatics, but because they were humans—overly deferential to authority and selfishly concerned with ambition and approval.

"I do not want to unlearn the lessons of Nazism," Ryrie emphasizes—and reemphasizes, again and again. "To recognize Hitler as representing a truly exceptional evil is the beginning of wisdom. My point, however, is that this recognition is only the beginning; it is not enough. It cannot bear the weight that our age is putting on it, and by now it is cracking under the strain." Even though "the appetite for telling its story is not fading"—my upcoming course on WWII quickly filled up during Bethel's last registration period, as it always does—the ethical consensus created by the crusade against Hitler seems to be unravelling. This is not simply Ryrie's cue to condemn what he labels the "dirty Right" of European and American politics. Based on lectures given during the Biden presidency, *The Age of Hitler* doesn't even mention Donald Trump until the half-way point, and only occasionally after that. Instead, Ryrie roots the weakening of the anti-Nazi consensus in everything from an overdue reckoning with injustices perpetrated by the Allies themselves to "the re-emergence, on both political extremes, of the most perennial prejudice of them all: antisemitism."

That consensus isn't entirely gone, and "it is still unusual to find a political leader in the democratic world who openly disdains the taboo against Nazism." Laughably, even Vladimir Putin justified his 2022 invasion of Ukraine as an "anti-Nazi" campaign against a government led by the Jewish descendant of

Holocaust victims. But Ryrie is most persuasive when he argues that an ethic birthed by World War II is ultimately inadequate.

It's not just that many modern-day foes aren't much like Nazis. ("We brought a Spitfire to a germ fight," says Ryrie of the British response to COVID-19, "and proved better at stirring wartime rhetoric than at effective public health policy.") More fundamentally, "deriving moral values from a war, any war, is a problem," since doing so leaves us with a "moral framework that valorizes just one set of tools, and a very dangerous set at that..." Because we've learned from the unique struggle against Hitler the lesson that "evil can be defeated by force if you oppose it wholeheartedly enough," we've tended to devalue negotiation, compromise, and other forms of peaceful conflict resolution, while failing to realize that "attempting to crush evil completely often only contaminates the soil with toxic debris. Tolkien was not wrong to warn of the consequences of trying to conquer Sauron with the Ring."

Still more problematic to Ryrie is "the whole business of using an exemplar of evil to set our moral compasses. It means that we now know what we hate, but we do not know what we love." Even if WWII has left us with "quite a deep understanding of evil"—and he's not so sure of that — "we have a pretty impoverished understanding of what philosophers used to call *the good*," lacking any meaningful sense of what to do with our rights and equality. Meanwhile, "defining our morals by the process of hatred has costs all of its own," such as "a certain inflexibility and brittleness" of political discourse that lacks "much space for forgiveness or redemption."

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The erudite Ryrie draws from a dizzying array of examples —some theology and ethics here, references to C.S. Lewis, J.R.R. Tolkien, and J.K. Rowling there, the histories of multiple countries and continents everywhere. Yet he doesn't offer empirical evidence so much as reasons to trust the personal intuitions that he suspects "are often more reliable than mere logic." Either his sweeping generalizations will feel right to you, or they won't.

But even if you read the first two sections of *The Age of Hitler* and don't see yourself clearly in Ryrie's versions of "How We Got Here" and "Where We Are Now," you may yet participate in his closing prediction for "Where We Go Next." For if Ryrie is right that cultural synthesis is the best, most likely resolution to our culture war, then Christians have a key role to play.

To the "instinctive conservative… who has proudly embraced traditional cultural and religious particularities," Ryrie warns that the "combative Christian conservatism" of MAGA and its cousins in Hungary and Russia offers nothing more than a "mirage of cultural success… doomed to dissolve into nothingness as we approach it, and to leave us stranded and thirsty in the desert." But while he sees the religious Right "hollowing itself out" as it becomes clearer that the substance of its politics have "less and less to do with their declared religion," Ryrie also expects a renewal of traditional values, not their rejection: "...since Christian ethics have deep roots and have successfully weathered some long winters in the past, some version of them will be what ends up springing up and recolonizing this cold earth."

Just in time to counsel secular progressives, whom Ryrie encourages to "open a dialogue with [the world's] deep-rooted traditions" that offer "deep wells of wisdom… the sorely needed abilities to forgive and to repent… deeply unfashionable but surprisingly practical ethical techniques" and "some beauty to spice all this tasteless gruel of truth and goodness." Ryrie commends religious and other rooted traditions that "are *endlessly* plural and self-critical, but not *boundlessly* plural and self-critical" as alternatives to the "universalizing ambition" that leaves progressives with "a quixotic sense of moral obligation to the whole of humanity" redolent of older justifications for Western empire.

It will require compromise on both sides, but Ryrie suspects that some synthesis is bound to happen, since the present paths for both Left and Right lead only to dead ends. But if progressives are to draw on "the traditions that, after all, actually helped fight the war against Hitler" while conservatives "fully and honestly own the anti-Nazi heritage," then perhaps those of us who never abandoned the example of Jesus but are still moved by the struggle against Hitler can serve a mediating role, helping our neighbors to see what it looks like to hold post-WWII "insights together with older and wider traditions."



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Adding Up the Evidence for God: A Social Scientist's Journey through Apologetics

CHARLES MURRAY. *TAKING RELIGION SERIOUSLY*. ENCOUNTER BOOKS, 2025. $29.99. 200 PP.

DANIEL K. WILLIAMS

I'm not easily surprised by works of Christian apologetics. Because I have been an avid student of apologetics since I was in high school—and because I have just finished writing a 400-page history of American Christian apologetics from the Puritans to the present—I have now read hundreds of apologetics books, as well as summaries of numerous others.[1]

And as much as I look forward with anticipation to every new work of Christian apologetics, hoping that I will encounter some new persuasive argument that I haven't heard before, I'll have to admit that more often than not I end up a bit disappointed, because most works of apologetics are fairly predictable. They deal with questions that previous apologists have been writing about for decades, if not centuries. In addressing those questions, they rarely if ever present arguments that previous apologists have not already proffered. Even works of cultural apologetics, which often depend more on storytelling than systematic argumentation, largely move across well- trodden ground.

But Charles Murray's *Taking Religion Seriously* is different. That's not because the arguments are new. Indeed,

[1] Daniel K. Williams, *The Search for a Rational Faith: Reason and Belief in the History of American Christianity.* Oxford University Press, 2026.

nearly everything Murray says in favor of Christian theism can be found in other books, as Murray himself readily acknowledges. What makes this book unique is that Murray has written the book not as a systematic argument intended to persuade the reader to become a Christian but as a window into his own thinking as he first encounters the evidence for Christianity and attempts to grapple with it. At this point in his journey, he is almost—but not quite—persuaded by the evidence for Jesus.

The book is especially valuable because Murray tries to be a relentlessly logical (but open-minded) thinker who systematically investigates all sides of every argument. His book summarizes the arguments for and against every proposition that he examines. Even if Murray is not yet persuaded that Jesus was the incarnate Son of God, his lengthy discussion of the evidence gives insight into how a sympathetic unbeliever might try to process Christian apologetic claims.

To be sure, Murray has come a long way in his belief. Until the late 1990s, he was an atheist or an agnostic. After growing up attending a liberal mainline Presbyterian church in a small town in Iowa, where the pastor did not believe in Jesus's divinity and where his churchgoing father didn't believe in heaven or hell, Murray decided as a Harvard sophomore that he didn't need religion. For the next three decades, as he passed through graduate school and then into a promising academic career, he never gave religion another thought. He believed in science, and he thought that science had pretty much ruled out the possibility of miracles or a divine creator. He also felt no need of religion in his own life. He found fulfillment in his work as one of the nation's best known (and most controversial) conservative social scientists.

Murray's 1994 book *The Bell Curve*, which argued for a biological (and racial) basis for IQ, made him a pariah in much of academia but also catapulted him to fame among conservatives. *The Bell Curve* sold 400,000 copies within two months of its release, making it one of the most widely distributed books of modern American sociology ever published. Murray found an academic home at the American Enterprise Institute, where he encountered Christian believers, but for a long time, he didn't pay much attention to their faith.

Although Murray's wife was a theologically liberal Quaker who attended weekly Friends meetings, he felt no need himself to meditate, pray, or think about the possibility of God. By his own admission, he has no innate attraction to spirituality. Music (whether secular or religious) almost never moves him. Religious ritual or liturgy has no place in his thinking. He tried praying only once as an adult (sometime in the 1990s, he recalls), and he found the experience "scary." It was safer to live with a strictly materialistic and rigidly logical universe.

I don't think that Murray ever read a book like Philip Yancey's *Rumors of Another World* (which argues that our love of music and beauty point us to God), but if he had encountered such a book during his long skeptical phase, I imagine that he would have been unimpressed. He didn't sense any internal longing for the transcendent, and he wasn't moved by the beauty of color or sound. An intuition of the spiritual might

have been fine for his wife, and as far as Murray was concerned, she was welcome to meditate at as many Quaker meetings as she wanted. Science and data were all he felt he needed.

FROM ATHEISM TO THEISM

Yet science and data are not as conducive to atheism as skeptics often assume. As a data-driven social scientist, Murray knew a lot about probability, which is why he realized in the early 2000s, after a study of the matter, that the atheistic view of the universe he had embraced wasn't just improbable—it was statistically impossible.

Martin Rees's *Just Six Numbers* (1999) shook Murray's atheism and prompted him to abandon it forever. Rees, a British physicist, noted that if the mathematical constants that govern the universe's physics were just slightly different, no life could exist. For instance, as Murray notes, stars are powered by the conversion of hydrogen into helium through nuclear fusion, which converts 0.7 percent of the hydrogen's mass into energy. If instead only 0.6 percent of the hydrogen's mass were converted into energy, "a proton could not bond to a neutron, helium could not be formed, and the entire process that produces the periodic table of elements would be foreclosed." And if as much as 0.8 percent of the mass of a hydrogen atom were converted to energy, "two hydrogen protons would be able to bind directly, and no hydrogen would remain. No hydrogen would mean no fuel for stars."

The same level of extreme precision was required for all of the other mathematical constants. For instance, if the electrical force was not exactly 10^{36} times stronger than the gravitational force, life would never have formed. Instead, if the electrical force was only 10^{30} times as strong as gravity, planets would never have formed and, even if they had, stars (including the sun) would run out of fuel in only 10,000 years, meaning that life would never have had time to evolve.

Murray realized that there were only three explanations that could be given for such a finely-tuned universe. The first possibility was that all of this had really formed by chance. But as he thought about the Big Bang, he realized that that was incredibly unlikely. Current scientific evidence suggests that the Big Bang is a non-recurring event. Between 10^{-43} seconds and 10^{-12} seconds after the Big Bang (that is, one trillionth of a second after the Big Bang), the strong nuclear force, the weak nuclear force, the electromagnetic force, and the gravitational force all emerged, creating the basis for an expanding universe that is precisely tuned for the formation of life on our planet. The chance of all of this happening randomly is 1 in 10^{123}, according to Roger Penrose, a Nobel laureate in physics. Murray quoted Stephen Meyer when describing Penrose's calculations: "If we tried to write out this number, there would be more zeros in the resulting number than there are elementary particles in the universe."

Penrose is a self-described agnostic. Rees says he doesn't believe in God either. But their findings about the finely tuned universe led Murray to rethink his own agnosticism, partly because he rejected the leading way that contemporary atheists (including Rees) explain the universe's appearance of design: multiverses. According to the multiverse theory, there

might really be 10^{123} universes (or more) outside of our own.

For those who embrace the multiverse theory, the improbable becomes probable if you simply expand the number of tries—and in this case, expand it to an almost unimaginably infinite degree. Rees considers multiverses probable, based on string theory. Murray read several books advocating multiverses before concluding that "investigations into multiverse theory have not yet yielded any empirical evidence for its validity." Multiverse theory is merely speculation—an interesting one, perhaps, but one without any empirical data to support it. Since Murray prides himself on being a strict empiricist, he couldn't base his views on the origin of the universe on such a flimsy flight of fancy that lacks any empirical support whatsoever. A more straightforward explanation, he decided, was that "a God created a universe that would enable life to exist."

Atheists commonly claim that the God hypothesis is just as far-fetched as multiverses are, but that's not Murray's view. He thinks that there are plenty of other pieces of evidence that point to God—which means that the idea of God is not simply a speculative hypothesis that we are forced to embrace because of a gap in our knowledge about what caused the Big Bang. Rather, it is a concept that fits all of the data that we have about the universe and ourselves.

For example, when we look within our own consciousness, we find an innate concept of right and wrong that can best be explained by the idea that we have a God-given sense of a fixed moral law, as C. S. Lewis argued. Murray is aware that there are naturalistic evolutionary explanations for the origins of a moral consciousness, but he notes that while those theories might explain why we feel innately that certain actions are right or wrong, they don't give us any confidence for believing that our moral intuitions are based on anything universally binding. If we want to say that what Hitler did was objectively evil, we have to draw on an objective moral standard that cannot be the product merely of naturalistic evolutionary forces.

And besides, Murray says, we sense moral imperatives that make no sense in an evolutionary framework. Evolution might give us the biological impulses to protect our own children, but why would anyone ever feel the need to sacrifice their life for someone they're not related to? Such altruism doesn't make sense from an evolutionary point of view—and therefore, it's an indication that perhaps there's more to the universe than naturalistic evolutionary theories alone can account for.

Ross Douthat's recent book *Believe* (2025) and Justin Brierly's *Why I Am Still a Christian* (2025) cover some of the same evidence that Murray cites, which will also be thoroughly familiar to anyone who has read much about intelligent design. But if this evidence is not exactly new to informed readers, it was new to Murray when he was first encountering it—and it was therefore life-changing.

Murray could have simply become a deist on the basis of his belief in a finely tuned universe. This, after all, was what the British mathematician Antony Flew did when he investigated the evidence for the origins

of the universe and the beginning of life. The result was his book, *There Is a God: How the World's Most Notorious Atheist Changed His Mind* (2008). Indeed, an understanding of the full implications for the Big Bang has caused more than one atheist or agnostic to rethink their assumptions, since, as Murray notes, the Big Bang sure looks like an act of creation.

But once Murray abandoned his atheistic assumptions, he didn't stop his investigations. After he opened himself up to the possibility of a God and to the existence of a non-material reality, he realized that there is other empirical evidence against a strictly material universe: near-death experiences and terminal lucidity (when people whose brains have mostly shut down become unexplainably lucid shortly before death).

Both near-death experiences and terminal lucidity can best be explained as evidence that consciousness is not solely caused by brain activity; humans have non-material souls that can continue to function and observe even without chemical reactions occurring in the brain. And souls can leave the body while continuing their observations, as some accounts of near-death experiences indicate. Murray read the works of skeptics who attempted to explain away near-death experiences on strictly materialistic grounds and was unconvinced. Skeptics cannot explain how people whose brains had shut down were able to hear conversations and observe phenomena while in a near-dead state; the theory that their souls continued functioning even while their brains did not seems to be the best explanation for what they experienced.

FROM DEIST TO (ALMOST) CHRISTIAN

Once Murray had empirical evidence to reject both atheism and materialism, he was ready to investigate the historical evidence for Christianity. Once again, he found that the evidence for the supernatural was far greater than he had once imagined.

Earlier in his life, he had dismissed the gospels as legendary, but Richard Bauckham's *Jesus and the Eyewitnesses* convinced him that there is good internal evidence for an early date for the gospels and that they consist mostly of history rather than myth. His book includes two full chapters defending the gospels' historicity and early dates and suggesting why the skeptical views of mainstream liberal biblical scholarship are based on unwarranted assumptions.

Murray also found that the evidence for Jesus's resurrection, as presented in such books as N. T. Wright's *The Resurrection of the Son of God*, was much stronger than he had initially expected. Skeptical attempts to explain away the resurrection were not very convincing, he decided.

I expected that at the end of the book, Murray would tell his readers that at the end of his 25-year quest, he had become a Christian. I knew from hints he had dropped throughout his book that he did not believe in biblical inerrancy, but I thought that in keeping with his rigorous logic, he would decide that the only reasonable answer to C. S. Lewis's famous trilemma (Was Jesus Lord, liar, or lunatic?) was "Lord."

I was wrong. Murray was deeply moved by Lewis's

Mere Christianity, and he wrestled at length with the trilemma. But in the end, he stopped just short of saying that Jesus was Lord.

"I now accept that Jesus of Nazareth represented himself as having a unique relationship with God—and suspect that he had such a relationship in fact," Murray concluded. But he shrank back from the implications of saying that Jesus was fully God in the flesh.

And so, he concluded, "I have yet to experience the joys of faith. When I'm around Catherine and others who have, I sometimes feel like a little boy whose nose is pressed against the window, watching a party he can't attend."

"I'm not done trying to join the party," Murray wrote. "Perhaps the door will open eventually. But even if it doesn't, I have much to be grateful for. My haphazard pilgrimage has already led me to believe that I live in a universe made meaningful by love and grace. That's a lot."

WHAT MIGHT PERSUADE MURRAY TO BECOME A FULL BELIEVER?

Murray's intellectual journey reminded me of the early nineteenth-century Harvard theology professor Andrews Norton. Like Murray, Norton collected a massive amount of evidence (in his case, hundreds of pages) to demonstrate the historicity of the gospels in the face of skeptical attacks from liberal German theologians. Like Murray, Norton argued that there were good empirical grounds for accepting the historical testimony of the miracles of the gospels, including Jesus's resurrection. Like Murray, Norton believed that the universe did show incontrovertible evidence of a divine designer.

But Norton was also a Unitarian. He did not believe that Jesus was God in the flesh. And, like Murray, he had little use for most of the Old Testament.

While the moderately conservative Unitarianism that Norton represented has largely disappeared from the American religious scene and is therefore unfamiliar to most of us, I think that understanding its possibilities and limitations gives us a good framework for understanding Murray.

Like the early nineteenth-century Unitarians, Murray is a strict rationalist and empiricist—but an open-minded one. Throughout his life, he has not been afraid to go against the grain of prevailing opinion and follow the data wherever he has thought it led. He has no use for political correctness or deference to prevailing academic fads. It doesn't faze him to think that perhaps most mainstream liberal biblical scholars in the academy are wrong; if the empirical evidence calls their late dating of the gospels into question, he's happy to argue against them, just as Norton did in his day.

But just as the early nineteenth-century Unitarians found the doctrine of the Trinity irrational and unacceptable, so Murray finds the related doctrine of the incarnation impossible to accept: "I say that in part because of my belief that God must not be anthropomorphized, and that to talk about a human-

like relationship with God violates that rule."

Like early nineteenth-century Unitarians, Murray has a very high respect for Jesus. Jesus was greater than any other religious teacher in world history, he believes. In fact, Jesus was probably greater than any other person who ever lived, and he had relationship with God that was closer than any other person has ever had. But, quoting approvingly the liberal pastor of his childhood Presbyterian church, Murray also says, "Jesus wasn't God. He was as much God as you can get into the human jar."

It is indeed incredible to think that the God who did the things that first impressed Murray—that is, created the universe in a trillionth of a second and aligned it along precise physical constants that made the earth uniquely primed for the origin of life—could have entered the world as a human being. Murray, in fact, considers that so unlikely that despite all the evidence from the gospels that Jesus, in fact, did claim to be God, he shrinks back from the implications of that finding and wants to settle for a Jesus who merely had a unique relationship with God.

Is there anything that would convince a strict rationalist like Murray to rethink his assumption that God's transcendence means that God could never be anthropomorphized by becoming a human being?

I think there is. Murray has spent two decades evaluating the evidence about God from history and science, but to get to the next stage, he may have to consider a different type of evidence—the internal evidence of the Bible.

This was Jonathan Edwards's favorite evidence for Christianity. His final book, which he died before completing, was *A History of the Work of Redemption and the Harmony of the Old and New Testaments*. This was a study of how the entire Bible is an internally consistent story of God's salvation of humanity through Christ. I think that if Murray applied his analytical skills to a study of the Bible's description of God's attributes and God's project of redeeming humanity, he would see that both the Old and New Testaments portray this theme with amazing consistency—and that the gospels' descriptions of Jesus are fully harmonious with both the Old Testament's portrayals of God and with the scriptural prophecies of a coming Messiah. Jesus's divine identity and his redemptive work on the cross cannot be separated from the gospels' portrayal of Jesus.

But as Murray admits, his aversion to an anthropocentric depiction of God prevents him from making this move. Though he doesn't say it outright, I suspect that his strong antipathy to anthropocentric portrayals of God stems from his belief that such depictions cheapen the majesty and power of God. The God who created the entire universe with such finely tuned precision could not possibly have entered the earth in human form, with all the limitations of a human being.

Some early nineteenth-century New England Unitarians felt the same way. Near the end of his life, President John Adams lampooned the idea of the incarnation by saying that he could not believe that the Creator "who produced this boundless Universe, Newton's Universe and Herschel's Universe, came

down to this little Ball to be spit upon by Jews."

But maybe instead of thinking of the incarnation as an unacceptable degradation of the perfect deity who created the universe, we could instead view these actions of the Creator as a voluntary self-emptying form of self-revelation that will make us marvel. Indeed, that's what Philippians 2 suggests. And it's the framework for the gospel narrative.

As Timothy Keller noted in his book *Jesus the King*, the gospel of Mark begins with an astonishing display of Jesus's power. For the first eight chapters of Mark, Jesus performs one miracle of healing after another, and everyone around him is continually amazed. Because Jesus's miracles were restorations of God's creation order, Jesus's miracles essentially revealed himself as the creator, setting right a creation that had fallen into disrepair. The crowds that marveled at Jesus's miracles were exhibiting a similar reaction to the one that Murray had when he realized the fine-tuned precision with which God designed the universe. That's the right reaction to have. We should marvel at God's power of creation.

But then, halfway through the gospel of Mark, Jesus pivots. He will not be the king that people expect him to be, he essentially tells his disciples. Instead, he will be the king who shows his glory by taking on the shame of the cross. The rest of the gospel is the story of the disciples' struggle to come to terms with what ultimately turns out to be an even more magnificent (and far more surprising) story of God's work than the creation alone could have led us to expect.

To be open to this story, Murray will have to be open to the possibility that God can reveal himself in more than numbers. But as someone who loves calculating probabilities, maybe he can ask himself how many other religions have come up with a story like this. The answer is none. What, therefore, is the probability that humans could have invented it on their own? What, especially, is the probability that if humans did invent it, the inventors would have been devout God-fearers from the world's most monotheistic culture—a culture uniquely primed to view such an idea as blasphemy? And what is the probability that hints foretelling parts of this story of incarnation would be interwoven throughout the entire Bible simply by chance?

The insights that Murray has reached on his spiritual journey so far are impressive, and I imagine that they may be helpful in convincing scientifically minded skeptics to consider the evidence from science and history that point to God's existence. We can learn a lot from Murray's open-minded determination to follow the data wherever it leads, even when it has challenged his atheistic assumptions. As a person who is perhaps on the road to Christian faith, he has accomplished a lot.

But I can't help but wonder how much greater Murray's testimony might be if he takes the additional step of reconsidering his skepticism about the incarnation. I hope that he'll look again at the biblical evidence with his characteristic open-minded willingness to reexamine his assumptions and follow the data. If he does, I imagine that he might be amazed by where the evidence leads him next.

As strange as it might seem, he might find that God's most amazing act in the universe's history did not occur a trillionth of a second after the Big Bang but rather about 2,000 years ago on a cross just outside Jerusalem.

But to reach that conclusion, he'll need to reconsider who exactly was hanging on that cross. If, as Christians believe, it was the same Creator who invented the mathematical constants on which the universe is framed, it changes the whole equation.



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Gardening and the Church Year

MATT MILLER. *LEAVES OF HEALING: A YEAR IN THE GARDEN*. BELLE POINT PRESS, 2024. $17.95. 140 PP.

GRACY OLMSTEAD

What would it have been like to watch Adam and Eve at work in God's Garden, prior to the Fall? Can you imagine Adam tending tomatoes or Eve pruning rose bushes?

No matter how strange such a vision might seem, according to the book of Genesis, the first man and woman were indeed gardeners. Their first vocation—and our first calling, as a species—was a mandate to create. God called these first humans to be "fruitful and multiply, and to fill the earth" not just with humans, but with all the fruits of life God had made. Adam and Eve were to spread Eden's beauty to every corner of the planet.

When the Fall happened, it broke our relationship with God and with each other. But it also marred our relationship to the earth itself—our gardenly calling was thrown into error. To become a gardener, from that day forward, was no longer easy or perfect. Yet we garden still. Something elemental in us, perhaps, draws us back to Edenic cultivation.

An essayist, English Professor at the College of the Ozarks, and online friend of many years, Matt Miller has long pondered the connections between soul, faith, time, and garden. In his book *Leaves of Healing: A Year in the Garden*, Miller invites readers into the garden and the church's liturgical year, reminding that seasons of heaven and earth are always inextricably intertwined.

Extensively quoting theologian Paul Griffiths, Miller explains in his introduction that there are two sorts of time. The first is the ceaseless ticking of the clock that the Greeks expressed as *chronos*, "the devastated and devastating

clock-time of our fallen existence." Miller explains that "*Chronos* never slows down, never gives us a break, and finds its period only in death." Griffiths describes this time as "metronomic": It marks the endless slippage of moments into mortality.

Yet there is a second experience of time, termed *kairos* in Greek. It refers to the right or opportune time—the moment for a decisive action, choice, or event. *Kairos* is qualitative, not quantitative. It is embodied in the moment when I prune tomatoes and smell their rich juices smeared across my hand; I remember what it was to smell this heady scent on my hands as a six-year-old, scavenging for backyard tomatoes. *Kairos* unfolds within seasonality, rhythms of being, and a vital sense of context. With *kairos,* time itself folds into pleats of shared experience, touching across profound temporospatial distances. As Griffiths puts it, *kairos* time is "systolic": It weaves each shared cycle or pattern into a larger tapestry, ruching moments like the empty tomb and Easter Sunday together across centuries.

Both gardening and liturgy, Miller argues, are *kairos* spaces. Their interlacing themes of life, death, resurrection, and renewal call us out of *chronos* and into eternity.

Miller says he wrote this book as an expression of "delight" in the garden and the liturgical year. In reality, however, I find its message more fully expressed in the first chapter, which begins amid the *chronos* of Covid. While the introduction defines both gardening and liturgy as "cycles of glory" or "glorious repetition," there is something very real about the way Matt expresses his relationship to gardening, place, and time in his first chapter. Here it is not glorious. It is full of weariness and bitterness. Here, the vision of Eden meets the Fall. As Matt puts it,

> "By the time the plague arrived … we ought to have been well positioned to take up a role as the perfect pandemic back-to-the-landers. We should have baked bread, picked vegetables, and laughed. Instead, I grew weary, utterly weary of my garden. With extra time at home, like many others, I worked hard on my garden through the spring and the summer. But by the end of the growing season I felt done. I felt frustrated, tired, unwilling to continue. I wanted to turn over the whole garden into grass. I wanted to move to the suburbs. I wanted to pack it all in."

This book thus unfolds amid a pandemic Lenten season and within a larger moment of communal and horticultural malaise for the author. It begins in *acedia*, that thorny vice so prone to those called to good work on God's earth. To me, as the reader, therefore, the "project" of *Leaves of Healing* seemed most closely tied to its title: What does it mean to find Eden in a fallen landscape and amid broken communities? What happens when the gardener has lost his love of gardening?

In response to *acedia* and Covid isolation, Miller limits his work and himself. He focuses inward, seeking a time of "self-examination and humility, two qualities that Ash Wednesday commends to all. To amend my life, in banishing sin or renewing care for my garden, I would need to practice both." He pares down his list of plantings, imposes a sense of creatureliness on his gardening vision, and then continues in the work he's been given to do. He spends the rest of the gardening

and liturgical year writing and gardening, seeking belonging and joy through the process. The volume moves from Lent to Easter, from Easter to Ordinary Time. But its frame is forever set by the weariness of the first chapter. And it is perhaps vital to start *Leaves of Healing* by reminding readers of the pains of *chronos*. Many people joke that time has not proceeded the same since 2020, and that 2020 itself was a year beyond years—a sort of time warp that trapped and mired us in its strange cadences. The pandemic itself, from a temporal perspective, was confusingly mottled and mixed. Each family had to learn new rhythms of being, and to inhabit ways that stepped outside of the metronomic nature of things.

For Miller, both liturgy and garden serve as *memento mori*—an admonition to remember one's death, to embrace both contemplation and humility among the everyday cadences of work. While the garden "doesn't kill us," he reflects, it does remind us "that we will die." Amid the pains of the Covid pandemic, he adds, "the work of the Lenten garden is to find out how that recognition is not a curse, but good news."

As Miller's essays enter the holy days of Palm Sunday, Maundy Thursday, Good Friday, and Easter, with their spring seasons and colors, the project steps further into the language of metaphor. Grafting, grapes, palms, and clear-cut forests—these gardening realities remind reader and author of larger truths. Miller tends to a bush or tree as he ponders ideas of beauty, brokenness, and belonging. A picture emerges of everyday objects, gardening habits, and living plants serving as talismans for a rich web of philosophical and spiritual realities.

Yet Miller's work is not reductive; he does not "use" the garden to glean personal insights. Rather, he casts light on the deep interrelatedness of things. While some chapters do feel a bit rushed in making these connections fulsome (a chapter on "Christ the King Sunday" touches on ecosystems and hierarchy but does not plunge as deeply into specific gardening habits), each essay nevertheless shares glimpses of a new perception of the garden and of God. The separation between the two, Miller repeatedly hints to readers, is paper-thin.

Earthly and earthy as gardening is, gardens have been a part of God's work and Gospel for a very long time. From the Garden of Eden to Gethsemane to the empty tomb with its resurrected Savior (who was mistaken for a Gardener), each garden beckons to soul as well as body. In a more personal sense, by uniting gardening to the liturgical calendar, we see a pattern in time that does not trap us but rather releases us from the woes of temporospatial absurdity. Gardening thus invites us into rhythms of embodied care that circumvent the solipsism and distraction of the age.

In the book's final portions, the year grows cold as it proceeds from Ordinary Time to Christmas and Epiphany, and the reader cannot help but wonder: Will Miller's efforts at inhabiting systolic time find success? Does the volume end with the delight Matt expresses at its beginning? Can we defeat *acedia?*

The answer, of course, is yes and no. Miller himself expresses some ambivalence over his successes by the end: "I began these essays hoping for a renewal of life and gardening," he writes,

> "practicing my Lenten disciplines in confident expectation. As my gardening year

> draws to an end … I cannot say I have found the healing that I sought. Tending one's own garden, whether metaphorically or literally, only gets one so far. Even the work I hoped to do in these essays has been called into question for me by the chaos of American culture today. Culture-building and long-term work like perennial gardening, writing works of literature, and creating a habitation in place can seem futile in a climate of suspicion and fear, callous indifference and preening judgment."

In the movements Miller takes from Lent toward Advent, from the brokenness of Covid toward the hope of a new year, one senses *acedia* rear its head occasionally. This, more than anything, seems to feed his sense of disappointment as the year draws to its close. It is a disappointment, the reader senses, not just in the trials of the garden—but in the bleak injustice and brokenness of the world itself, as it beats along in its metronomic rhythms. How to find contentment in the garden when the larger world proceeds apace in its chaos and cruelty?

These are hard questions to answer. "Gardening and liturgy are the answer" seems trite in response to the chaos, uncertainty, and evil of our world. Yet in *Leaves of Healing*—its vision of a humble garden well-loved, and its attendant determination to attend to the eternal and the quotidian—we also see those glimpses of hope and thanksgiving that promise health in both this life and the next.

A couple of times, Miller disagrees with Fyodor Dostoevsky's famous claim that "beauty will save the world." Beauty, at least in our everyday conceptions of it, is not enough to save the world, he explains. I wonder, however, as I conclude *Leaves of Beauty:* Perhaps this pull to garden in a broken world is the ultimate argument for beauty's power over our hearts, bodies, and minds. In Boethius's *Consolations of Philosophy*, Lady Philosophy offers this concluding poem to the jailed (and soon to be executed) philosopher:

> "Father of earth and sky, You steer the world By reason everlasting. You bid time Progress from all eternity. Yourself Unshifting, You impel all things to move. No cause outside Yourself made you give shape To fluid matter, for in You was set The form of the ungrudging highest good. From heavenly patterns You derive all things. Yourself most beautiful, You likewise bear In mind a world of beauty, and You shape Our world in like appearance. You command Its perfect parts, to form a perfect world."

Boethius hints here at a systolic beauty that, as it draws our eyes to the Divine, Himself "most beautiful," heals and restores all that is broken. In glimpsing Him, the Perfect Gardener, we too glimpse this "world of beauty" that lies beyond all brokenness, beckoning us out of despair.

Perhaps when we take up this first work of Adam and Eve, this ancient identity-shaping vocation, we are tapping into a little bit of Eden time, an Edenic vision of beauty. Though we may not always *feel* it, the garden beckons to its workers, assuring them "all shall be well, and all manner of thing shall be well."

As Miller has noted in interviews, the end of this book

marks a move away from the garden that formed its crux of self-discipline and attention. His family moves from their rural home to be closer to community, work, and church. One might expect sorrow in such a parting, but Miller himself expresses hope—for in this move, he writes, he must leave "my garden now with empty hands, offering it and all it contains as glory and honor and power to the one in whose ceaseless attention I will work out all my days." This is where we find joy: in the gift and givenness, the offering up with empty hands. *Acedia* loses its power in the trust that, while our own intentions and efforts are forever flawed, there is One who attends perfectly. He alone knows all our needs.



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HOMO ET MACHINA

JOEL J. MILLER. *THE IDEA MACHINE: HOW BOOKS BUILT OUR WORLD AND SHAPE OUR FUTURE.* PROMETHEUS BOOKS, 2025. $34.95. 344 PP.

LUCY S. R. AUSTEN

People who write books spend a remarkable amount of time writing about, well, books. Fictional characters from Woolf's Orlando to Tolstoy's Pierre Bezukhov to Austen's Dashwood sisters to Cervantes' Don Quixote to Wu's Sun Wukong reveal themselves through their relationship to reading and writing. Non-fiction books exploring our relationship to books make up a tidy genre of their own. Biographies of writers abound. It's all a little self-referential, a little *meta*, but it makes sense: Writers and readers enjoy books and think they're important. But what's so special about these little bundles of words that have captured our attention for so long?

While many books-about-books tilt their focus toward things like content, effect on character, or just sheer enjoyment of reading, Joel J. Miller's *The Idea Machine* stands out in its consideration of *the book* primarily as an apparatus for facilitating thought. At its most fundamental, Miller writes, "The book is a portable collection of written ideas, designed to elevate the human mind beyond its natural limits of experience, memory, distance, and time." The centrality of a book in Augustine's conversion story—"take and read!"—provides a springboard for demonstrating this thesis.

Miller divides his project into four parts: Basics, Developments, Applications, and Reflections. The first two sections offer a fresh and often humorous review of the evolution of the book from its beginnings as cuneiform-on-clay accounting records through wax, papyrus, parchment, and paper, scrolls and codices, the invention of the printing press, and so on. The regular illustrations supporting the text—manuscripts, carvings, paintings, mosaics, and, eventually, photographs—add to the enjoyment. And Miller's paying attention to not just the *how* of the changing book. The *why* and the *then what* provide even readers who know the basics of the tale with new insights and further food for thought.

MANUSCRIPT EVIDENCE

The Idea Machine shows us a world where books begin as capital, inaccessible to most and accumulated by a few. They are expensive to produce and slow to read, but for those happy few they augment memory, facilitate the honing and comparison of ideas, and offer ways to "explain the world, even the human heart" across space and time. These advantages far outweigh the concerns of the change-hesitant about whether reliance on books will weaken human memory or delude people into thinking possession of facts equals wisdom. Those who can compile libraries, then create tools to keep track of—and search for—what's in them.

As the centuries pass, the use of books spreads—sometimes quietly, like ripples in a pond, and sometimes with the intensity of a wildfire—in a self-perpetuating cycle with ingredients including the Pax Romana, the Christian Church, cheaper materials, and more accessible formatting. So does the quantity of books, both in number of volumes and in individual titles. Techniques for finding what one wants in this growing body of information grow right along with books and readers. Concerned attempts to curb undesirable elements of the booksplosion become more widespread as well (though no more effective).

In "Applications," Miller explores how these aspects of book *qua* book (portability, durability through time, extension of memory, refinement of thought, access to the ideas of others, ease of reference, affordability, etc.) continue to shape and be shaped by the modern era. "The history of science," he writes, "is the history of books in various states of dress (loose notes, first drafts, second editions)." This could describe each of the overlapping categories he examines: science, government, abolition, social conscience, and the rise of the Information Age.

This section contains some of the most beautiful writing of the book. Miller chooses vivid cases in point for each category. Ground-breaking scientists record observations over time, then share them widely in books, leading to major advances and changes in thinking. Revolutionary politicians read books "of and about the past to orient themselves in the present," then write books of their own on their way to creating new forms of government. Enslavers grasp at power by restricting literacy while enslaved people "force a reckoning" with dehumanization through their reading and writing. Novelists open readers' eyes to the interiority of people very different from themselves, challenging barriers between sexes, classes, and races. It becomes clear that, even for the most inveterate non-reader, it is impossible to overstate the importance of the book in every aspect of life.

MACHINES TO THINK WITH

Precisely because of this importance, those of us who love books tend to worry about the much-documented decline in the percentage of people reading them—and this certainly includes Miller himself. Many of us also tend to think of books in opposition to digital tech, particularly given the possible role of the PC, the smartphone, and social media in said decline. This is an uneasy position, since we've been using computers

to facilitate the world of books for some time now. I'm typing up this review on a laptop, and you may well be reading it on a screen. Even Wendell Berry (may his shadow never grow less) has publishers who use computers to get his writing into the hands of readers.

But one of Miller's main points is that even when we're reading a bound, printed book (or a papyrus scroll, or a wax tablet, etc.) we're using technology. Books are tools we have developed to extend our capabilities. He sees the digital revolution as merely one more stage in a process that stretches back to ancient Sumer. From the title page on, *The Idea Machine* makes deliberate use of language that emphasizes the blurred lines between print and pixel. Books are "information technology," "hardware as well as software," an "external hard drive of the mind, cloud storage for your head." They are, to quote I. A. Richards, "machines to think with."

And as Miller points out, once there are more than a few of them, books are much more useful if there's a way to look for things in them without having to read all of every tome. An index lets us search an individual book. Catalogs let us search libraries. But even in the first half of the 20th century, readers were lamenting the way the "growing mountain" of pertinent material that needed to be digested to stay abreast of their field was miring their work. The Internet made searching faster and easier. But it also, in a continuation of the cycle that has repeated throughout the history of the book, increased the amount of material to be searched. So what comes next as we cope with this "information overload"? Miller suggests it's generative AI.

EXTENDING THE BOOK?

If the book is an extension of the mind's ability "to preserve information and expand access to it, to organize and utilize data and analysis, to build on what we know and broaden what we can learn," then the search capacity and data analysis offered by AI can be seen as "an extension of [the book's] affordances." By "atomizing books down to discrete blocks of information," AI offers the possibility that readers could spend less of their time looking for existing data and more of their time making new connections and discoveries in that data. He offers such recent examples as researchers from Israel and from the University of Chicago making breakthroughs in the translation of cuneiform tablets, University of Notre Dame scholars transcribing and search-enabling medieval manuscripts, and a team accessing carbonized scrolls from Vesuvius without damaging them, all with the use of AI. Both the theory and the practice here seem heavily weighted toward researchers and historians. What is lacking is a consideration of how this or other aspects of AI might affect poets and novelists.

Of course, while the "atomization" of books through AI could provide a way to deal with the sea of information, it also disrupts some of the benefits previous changes in technology brought us, whether the organizational gains that came with the codex, or the advantages of "scholars referencing the same texts" that came with printing. As Miller notes, "progress is a story we tell retrospectively," and the aspects of a world shaped by books that we now see as positive weren't necessarily a given. Nothing here excludes the possibility that, as Gabriel Rossman writes for *Compact,* reliance on AI in the first 16 years of education may mean "we run out of people with motivation and background to

learn, know, and do" even the basics of books, let alone exciting things at higher levels. In the introduction to *The Idea Machine*, Miller describes the book as "a victim of its own success." He thinks the importance of the book is underappreciated. Only time will tell if the digital revolution will prove his words more broadly true.

But *The Idea Machine* reminds us that "the way things were before" is no guarantee of goodness. (Think Renaissance humanists reviving ancient wisdom with the goal of ushering in a new Golden Age, only to revive its flaws and errors as well in a sort of keeping-the-bathwater-along-with-the-baby moment.) Technological change—and fear of technological change—in the realm of the book has been disruptive again and again over the centuries, and again and again we've adapted and found new benefits in new technology. After more than two decades of involvement with books as a salesman, writer, editor, and publisher, Miller remains optimistic about their future.

SHAPING THE WORLD AND OUR OWN HEARTS

Perhaps the best reason for both optimism and pessimism about technology of any kind is the fact that human beings are behind its invention and use. Despite massive cultural and technological differences across time and space, human beings seem to keep drawing from the same common pool of affections and temptations, flaws and gifts, down through millennia. It's this that makes classic books *classic*. We're still reading about Gilgamesh and Sappho and Beowulf and the gang because all these thousands of years later, they still speak to us. From a Christian perspective, human beings are warped because we are part of a damaged world—and beautiful because we are made in the image of a loving, creative God. We leave the fingerprints of both aspects of our nature on our work.

AI-interested readers may find *The Idea Machine* reinforcing their readiness to experiment while also offering food for thought for protecting the aspects of the book they value. AI-concerned readers may see continued cause for caution while also finding encouragement in reminders of human and bookish resilience. But perhaps the most important take-away is that we consider what *makes* what Miller calls in his conclusion "humane applications" for tech of any stripe—and how we get there.

The history of the book shows us that human frailty and cruelty have led to horrors, and that human goodness and strength have created powerful change for the better. We can and do use our creativity to harm and to help ourselves, each other, the plants and animals, and even the dirt that sustains us. Our technologies have certain leanings that tend to shape us as we use them—"they suggest some uses more than others"—but the ways we use any technology also shape the direction it leans. Which of our human impulses is most formative for a given technology? Is a particular technology influencing us more for good or for ill? How can we tell when we see behind us such a long train of unintended consequences?

Fittingly, books can help us wrestle with these

questions, allowing us to join in thousands of years of conversation about what makes a good human life. So can conversations in real-time—whether face-to-face or via tools like apps—with fellow questioners. But as we make our pilgrimage through the ever-changing world, as we ponder the implications of our technologies and choose which to use and how to use them, the most important tool at our disposal remains unchanged: the pursuit of wholeness—of integrity, all-of-a-piece-ness, lovingkindness.



LUCY S. R. AUSTEN IS GLAD TO LIVE IN A WORLD IN WHICH THERE ARE BOOKS. HER WRITING HAS APPEARED AT PUBLICATIONS INCLUDING CHRISTIANITY TODAY AND THE OXFORD CENTRE FOR LIFE WRITING. SHE IS THE AUTHOR OF ELISABETH ELLIOT: A LIFE AND THE FORTHCOMING MIDDLE-GRADE BIOGRAPHY, THE STORY OF ELISABETH ELLIOT: THE MISSIONARY WHO FOLLOWED GOD INTO THE UNKNOWN.

Virgil and the Quest for the Golden Age of Mankind

The following excerpt from Nadya Williams, *Christians Reading Classics: An Introduction to Greco-Roman Classics from Homer to Boethius* (2025), is published with permission from Zondervan Academic.

NADYA WILLIAMS

A few years ago, when we still lived in Georgia, I planted a small garden in my yard. Since the earth under the thin carpet of grass—mostly wild onions, to be honest—was all exhausted clay, I bought a few bags of real dirt all jazzed up with Miracle-Gro. I wasn't sure how all of this would work, but I knew the basics: You stick some seeds in this dirt in the spring once night frost is no longer a danger and you try to remember to occasionally water and weed the soil. Eventually, some green edible stuff will sprout, keeping the family supplied with zucchini and radishes all summer long.

The experiment sort of worked during this first year. The radishes were anemic and mostly grew green tops. We used them for salad—it was not the best, but we felt that we were eating the work of our hands. At least the zucchini and squash lived up to expectations, producing abundantly until fall. But in the second year, a worm got into the soil and all the zucchini and squash wilted. I suddenly understood how the original Jonah (not my middle son—his namesake) felt when his beloved plant died.

In the third year, I tried planting okra, hearing how well this native African plant does in the Georgia heat. Then

we went on a two-week family vacation and I forgot that I had even planted anything. Imagine my surprise later that summer when massive okra plants actually flourished in my tiny garden, producing gorgeous pods that are so delightful when sautéed in some olive oil with a little bit (or a lot) of garlic.

I think of the description of the garden of Eden in Genesis 2. It flourished—it just did. The curse of the fall made farming and gardening the hard work that they are today. Long before Christ, ancient mythology also had similar stories—tales of a long-gone time of effortless flourishing for all living things. Ancient writers were convinced that there had once been a golden age of mankind. During this time, as the Greek poet Hesiod reflected, people were close to the gods, plants flowered without requiring much care, and diseases stayed away, allowing people to live much longer and more enjoyable lives. Romans additionally connected this golden age with their god Saturn, who ensured the flourishing of peace and agriculture.

Over half a millennium after Hesiod, an ambitious Roman politician made the restoration of the golden age of mankind the focus of his political image. To be fair, much restoration seemed to be needed in the broken Republic of his day. Like all politicians, he knew that he was certainly the right man for the job.

After a century of steadily escalating political instability and outright violence in the Roman Republic, Julius Caesar's grandnephew and adopted heir somehow emerged as the last man standing in 31 BC, when he defeated Mark Antony and Cleopatra in the Battle of Actium. But the resulting peace was initially uneasy. Over the ensuing decades until his death in AD 14, Augustus carved out a new and unprecedented degree of power for himself. Today we call him Rome's first emperor—but during his lifetime he actually went by the more demure title of *princeps*, first citizen. In this capacity, he embarked on restoring the Golden Age of Saturn in Rome. But how to do it?

This political underpinning is crucial for understanding the Augustan literary boom. Great art can flourish more easily in a time of peace and stability, especially when patronage exists. Since many Augustan writers were not independently wealthy, they needed patrons. Additionally, Augustus was, we could say, the original culture warrior.

What is a subtle way to effect political and social change in a society under stress? Augustus understood that changing the culture was key to making his desired changes "stick." And changing the culture meant, in this case, promoting the message of restoring peace, joy, and flourishing—of people, of nature, and of Rome. And so the Augustan propaganda focused on all things beautiful—having public gardens and festivals all around Rome, commissioning new art to beautify the city, and subsidizing a whole cadre of poets and prose writers. Preeminent among them was the poet Vergil. Augustus also threw regular public feasts because (it turns out) people of all ages and in all periods of human history have appreciated a free lunch.

Augustus was not a very likable guy, but he knew the value of beautiful words in renewing culture and the spirits of people worn down by decades of civil war and political instability. In writing stunning poetry to please Augustus, earn a salary, and encourage

the Roman people all in one fell swoop, Vergil's first choice of topic in his poetry does not seem political at first glance: farming. It's just about loving the land, working it, and seeing it flourish again. And yet ever present under the surface are the reminders of the civil wars that were still in living memory. Vergil repeatedly reminds his readers that only Augustus maintains this peace that in turn allows the humble bees to do their work again. But more Romans need to grow in the virtues that will allow them to support the state in various ways.

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> "Go to the ant, you sluggard;
> consider its ways and be wise!
> It has no commander,
> no overseer or ruler,
> yet it stores its provisions in summer
> and gathers its food at harvest" (Proverbs 6:6-8).

So wrote Solomon in his Proverbs to encourage the people of Israel, but it could just as easily have been written by Vergil in late first-century BC Rome to inspire the Age of Augustus. The wise ant, Solomon notes, is a wonderful role model of industriousness for people, who might be tempted to be lazy when the weather is nice. But the easy-come fruits of summer should not lull one into relaxing. Without storing away provisions for winter—without hard work all summer long—one will starve. The agricultural life is an annual cycle that predictably repeats—or, better, renews itself—year after year. By necessity it also conditions people in a number of virtues.

Vergil opens his agricultural epic poem *Georgics* on a similar note, with an ode to bees and the agricultural life:

> "I'll begin to sing of what keeps the wheat fields happy,
> Under what stars to plough the earth, and fasten vines to elms,
> What care the oxen need, what tending cattle require,
> Maecenas, and how much skill's required for the thrifty bees."

The bees are hard workers, but the farmer must also labor to support them if he is to profit from their labor. Therein lies the value of both the bees and the farmers as role models for Augustus's new golden age.

It is quietly normal and glorious to write beautiful epic poetry on some of the most mundane of actions—ploughing the wheat fields, tending grape vines, caring for beasts of burden and dairy cattle, and keeping bees. The ideal farm life was entirely self-sufficient—able to produce everything needed for life. But *Georgics* is not the work of a farmer! Vergil is a voluntary exile from the world of farming. He is now an urban poet who waxes eloquent over the life of a farmer to his patron, Maecenas, who is an urban (and urbane) wealthy businessman.

But the bees are also natural poets and thus fitting companions to Vergil's work. They produce their own steady rhythmic music as they go about their work. They cannot stop their steady buzzing any more than they can stop making honey. In this regard, they are

no different from the poet, who also cannot stop creating verse.

We gain an important perspective from knowing that while the poem has a didactic feel, Vergil's audiences were fellow well-to-do urban dwellers, appreciators of poetry but only admiring farming from afar. The farmers he lauds were too busy taking care of their land. Besides, a full generation before Vergil, much of Italy had already been taken over by wealthy senators and speculators buying up small farms to consolidate their own massive estates. The small farmers of the mid-Republic were long gone, displaced into cities and replaced by slave labor working the large-scale farms belonging to absentee landlords. But Vergil is in the midst of this loud absence, still praising farmers. His work seems to suggest that role models do not have to be real—they just have to inspire.

The independent small farmer, self-sufficient in all his needs, is a creature more legend than reality in the age of Vergil and Augustus. His ideal as painted in poetry echoes modern tradlife more than actually farming life in any historical period. In reality, he is vulnerable—subject to natural forces over which he has no control. Indeed, *Georgics* concludes with a vivid and visceral description of a plague that once devastated the cattle and also threatened the farmer himself. All this work is necessary—one cannot do without it. But doing it all is still no guarantee of success, either—yet failure may be costly.

Ultimately, *Georgics* ends on a note of despair. Even Augustus can only do so much to restore a true golden age. Plagues will still happen, even under the rule of the self-proclaimed prince of peace—who, of course, wasn't the real Prince of Peace. These plagues will befall any good farmers who are left. But then, plagues also happen to poets. Death spares no one—yet the bee doesn't care. Despair will get you nowhere. Besides, there is too much work still left to do. The ant agrees.



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TO DABBLE OR NOT TO DABBLE

KAREN WALROND. *IN DEFENSE OF DABBLING: THE BRILLIANCE OF BEING A TOTAL AMATEUR*. BROADLEAF BOOKS, 2025. $27.99. 211 PP.

NATHANIEL MARSHALL

I have lived a strange and wonderful life.

In some ways it has been quite normal. I had a warm Southern California childhood with happy memories of a loving family and playing in the park, long days spent at Disneyland and the beach and grandma's house—or as my mother called it during summer break, "Grandma Camp."

And yet this vanilla exterior hides a complex, flavorful filling that has been slowly injected over the course of my life. Soccer and basketball and figure skating and cheerleading; piano and cello and clarinet and beatboxing; Mandarin and watercolor painting and theology and plumbing; chiropterology (the study of bats—think winged mammal, not baseball) and philosophy and raising chickens and knitting; acting and gardening and writing and dancing.

You could say that I've been a bit of a dabbler. A chronic amateur.

This made Karen Walrond's new book, *In Defense of Dabbling: The Brilliance of Being a Total Amateur*, of immediate interest to me. The American milieu has given rise to "workaholism" and "perfectionism" and "hustle culture," against whose backdrop Walrond's call to something different strikes a refreshingly radical tone. Drawing on the

etymology of the word "amateur"—which denotes "lover" with the connotation of "a lover of something" or "doing something for pleasure or interest"—Walrond encourages her reader to let hobbies remain hobbies, to resist the cultural and market pressures that expect and reward making every hobby into a profitable hustle, to cast off the crushing weight of perfectionist tendencies, to counter the narrative that "the acquisition of money, power, and mastery is the only way to live a successful life." She wants us to do things "simply for the joy of doing them," for the love of the proverbial game.

Why is this a worthy goal? To what end is amateurism ordered? Walrond's goal aligns with humanistic psychology: we should rid ourselves of all that would frustrate the attainment of self-actualization and transcendence. For Walrond, this can happen through sustained practices in which one has rejected the allure of expertise. Practicing amateurism is ultimately a form of wholistic self-care. But as much as I love this basic idea of doing things for their own sake and agree that this enriches one's life, I am not satisfied with this justification, for reasons I will explain in due course. But first, an overview of the way of the amateur.

THE GIST OF AMATEURISM

In order to delineate pressure-laden expertise from amateurism—which, as the book's title indicates, is practiced by "dabbling" or "trying an activity for a short period"—Walrond spends the first chapter enumerating the "Seven Attributes of Intentional Amateurism." They are *curiosity*, *mindfulness*, *self-compassion*, *play*, *stretch zone*, *connection*, and *wonder and awe*.

You'll notice that together these sketch the shape not of a particular practice but of an internal disposition. Assembled well, these hedge in a space where amateurism can grow and bear its fruit while keeping out capitalist critters and the wild beast of perfectionism. Walrond spends the first chapter defining each of the Seven Attributes, then from the third to the penultimate chapter provides anecdotes that illustrate her journey of learning each one, before finally arriving at the pinnacle of psychologist Abraham Maslow's hierarchy of needs: transcendence—or, as she explains it, "the evolution from our individual bests to our *collective* bests."

Before diving into her Seven Attributes, Walrond takes the second chapter to do some framing to point a way forward. First of all, these Attributes must be internally habituated by practices. One must dabble. Dabble with what? Which practices? It's left up to the reader, although she recommends looking in five places to find options: activities you loved as a child, those you would do if you were ten years younger or older, talents you wish you had, activities done on your most playful vacation, and the types of social media content you follow. From these veins can be mined the raw activity-materials for amateur praxis. And if that exercise isn't helpful, in an appendix she gives a list of over two-hundred practices to help get the juices flowing. Secondly (and smartly, I think), she reminds us that bound up in this project of amateurism as self-care is our *spirit*—meaning, one's chosen practices must carry in them the promise of metaphysical benefit if one dabbles aright. Finally, she

anchors the possibility of thriving to rest and leisure, the context in which dabbling is meant to occur.

In the end, the author understands intentional amateurism to be an act of rebellion in line with Wendell Berry's *Manifesto: The Mad Farmer Liberation Front*: "…every day do something that doesn't compute… Work for nothing." She wants her reader to thrive, "detaching from perceptions, being expansive, [and] feeling connected to self and universe."

The question remains: if we follow the path she has mapped out, will we arrive at the summit of transcendence? To quote the hobbit Merry Brandybuck, "I wouldn't count on it."

MY THOUGHTS

If my review section seemed short and rather lacking in substance, you understand my first gripe. There wasn't much more for me to review. In fairness to the author, her book is meant as a work of practical guidance rather than a work of theory. And yet I couldn't avoid disappointment when each of the chapters on the Seven Attributes merely supplied personal anecdotes and litanies of experts telling me what that Attribute would produce without deeper exploration of the dynamic interplay between mind, morals, body, and spirit. It felt very "Source: trust me bro." Initially I thought that the definitions and descriptions of the Attributes in chapter one were summaries and further development would come with each Attribute's respective chapter. Alas, my record of perfect predictions has been marred.

The fundamental problem with the book runs deeper than my disappointment, though: The solution it proposes can't escape its own diagnosis, and this results in some rather serious contradictions. Let's look again at Walrond's main argument. She suggests that leisurely amateurism combats the twin ill effects of the chronic pursuit of expertise: the burnout of never-ending production on the one hand and psychologically suffocating perfectionism on the other. We will look at each part of the problem in turn.

The chronic pursuit of expertise—a high level of skill or knowledge in a particular area—is bad in Walrond's view because it is pregnant with capitalist meaning and driven by perfectionist motivations. Or if "bad" is too strong, then at least "undesirable." Is this always the case? Well… almost always. An exception? *Being an intentional amateur*. The very act of defining amateurism with criteria by which it is best accomplished invites the possibility of becoming an *expert* amateur. And the invitation is not left implied: She wants you to master this! She wrote a whole book on it! But if one is an expert, then, by definition, one is no longer an amateur. Amateurism, then, is defeated by the expertise it seeks to displace.

Reducing the human to no more than a producer is one outcome of expertise, we are warned. To say it another way, our human nature is put in service to outcomes. By taking up intentional amateurism and avoiding expertise, by engaging in practices simply for the love of doing them, do we thereby avoid becoming factories with feet? Perhaps in a material or economic sense, sure, but there is an invisible outcome towards which Walrond points us from the

beginning and it lies beyond the practices themselves: self-care, self-actualization, transcendence. These are not mere byproducts; they are the goal. By definition, then, one does not do these practices simply for the love of doing them (even if one happens to love doing them!). Rather, people instrumentalize the practices in order to produce some other desired end. So then, amateurism as an antidote for production doesn't have legs.

Expertise has a mutually reinforcing relationship with perfectionism. Walrond quotes researcher Brené Brown who writes, "Perfectionism is the belief that if we live perfect, look perfect, and act perfect, we can minimize or avoid the pain of blame, judgment, and shame." Blame, judgment, and shame all imply a social ecology in which what one does is viewed by others. The fuel of perfectionism is appearance. Curiously, Walrond introduces a minor theme early in the text worth noting: "how to be interesting." Whether she means to or not, she has replaced one kind of appearance with another; she has swapped perfection with interest, both of which depend on the value judgment of others. "Being interesting" is just "being perfect" by another name, and the pressure of "being perceived as" has not been removed. Amateurism once again fails to solve the core problem, and rather shows itself to be part of it.

Some of my other issues include: her squishy use of "spirituality" which is always in reference to therapeutic or psychological ideas; calling the enterprise "spiritual" but then putting distance between the practitioner and the "mystical or woo-woo"; calling God "She"; using Jesus' Name as a phrase of exasperation; her desire to "lift the soul" but a failure to say to where or to whom it is being lifted; and her desire to "transform [hobbies] from being responsibilities that *require our attention*, to activities that energize us," yet, paradoxically, speaking positively of paying attention at multiple points.

Despite Walrond's longing to transcend beyond the forces that flatten us—a good and worthy goal—she can't seem to escape the immanent frame. She sees the value in doing something for its own sake yet cannot help but instrumentalize it. Why?

ESCAPING TOTAL WORK

In his essay *Leisure: The Basis of Culture*, Catholic philosopher Josef Pieper asks with annoyance, "Is there a sphere of human activity, one might even say of human existence, that does not need to be justified by inclusion in a five-year plan and its technical organization?" Walrond and Pieper share many of the same concerns (which we might collectively label "dehumanization") and perhaps a starting point (that humans are defined by their productive activity) in common. Pieper would recognize in Walrond's book a reaction to the very thing that repulsed him, what he calls "total work." Total work is a "vast utilitarian process in which our needs are satisfied, and…tied to such an extent that the life of the working man is wholly consumed by it."

Total work reduces our human existence, and therefore all our activity, to the useful, the productive, or what Byung-Chul Han, in his *Vita Contemplativa*, has likewise called the "in-order-to." It's not that

work is wrong or bad. Quite the opposite! But there is more to our humanity than what we produce to supply common need. Hunting for food, for example, is different from an English country dance; the end of hunting is beyond itself, but the end of dancing is in itself. Hunting is useful; dancing is useless. Both are truly human. Total work logic expands the domain of use to cover that of the useless, thereby subjugating it to use. Leisure is bound within activity. Rest becomes impossible because even rest is a sort of work, and ultimately answers to it.

It seems to me that Walrond has been captured unawares by total work logic, resting "in order to," which makes her ultimate aim unattainable. She intuits many of the right things but does not have a worldview that allows them to fruitfully cohere. In fact, Pieper predicted this impossibility when he asked whether Humanism is up to the task of combatting total work, concluding that no, it was not. Why? Because it is not rooted in *divine worship*. "Cut off from the worship of the divine, leisure becomes laziness and work inhuman."

Walrond is anxious to avoid the accusation of laziness (when understood as "unproductive") and the inhumanity of work, and sees dabbling as the means, aimed at self-care. And yet this is precisely why it won't work: It binds rest iron-clad to the world of activity, impenetrable by the transcendent, whereas leisure instead comes as a gift from the divinity she gestures towards but never names—the God who made Sabbath for man and celebrates it with him.

A true amateur must first be a lover of God. From that well-ordered love alone can the brilliance of amateurism begin to shine forth.



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A Biography of Paradise Lost

ALAN JACOBS. *PARADISE LOST: A BIOGRAPHY*. PRINCETON UNIVERSITY PRESS, 2025. $24.95. 224 PP.

WILLIAM TATE

In 1667, the poet John Milton published *Paradise Lost*, an epic poem about the fall of man. Milton's dogmatic emphases in this poem "helped make him one of the most despised writers in history, and *Paradise Lost* one of the most despised poems, though also one of the most admired," reflects Alan Jacobs in his new volume, part of the Princeton University Press series, Lives of Great Religious Books. Jacobs makes it his task to understand these radically opposing reactions.

Jacobs was a good choice to write this volume. He is, first, a careful and experienced reader of the poem, which he has taught many times. But second, he is not a Milton specialist. This is an advantage for this project since he writes as a generalist and for a general literate audience. Finally, as he explains, his feelings for Milton and the poem are mixed; the benefit is that this "biography," though it appreciates the excellences of *Paradise Lost*, never declines into hagiography.

Jacobs begins, properly, by questioning whether *Paradise Lost* ought to be regarded as a great religious book. Distinguishing between a "*functional* definition of religion" and a "*dogmatic* definition," he acknowledges (along with C. S. Lewis) that *Paradise Lost* is not functional, not devotionally enriching in the way that, for example, George Herbert's poetry has been for many readers. Milton's poem fits, rather, under the dogmatic definition of religion, since "in it Milton is passionately concerned to identify certain central beliefs of the Christian faith."

Readers' perceptions of Milton the man have frequently influenced their reception of *Paradise Lost* (and vice versa), a fact that justifies Jacobs's survey of Milton's life in his first chapter. Milton knew that he wanted to write an epic early in his career as a poet. Why was this poetic ambition delayed? Jacobs surveys the circumstances of Milton's early life in London and then Cambridge, explaining that "*his* concerns were not economic, or even, at first, strictly political. He was a learned man, one inclined first to the service of poetry and second to the service of the church." Although his family expected that he eventually would take orders in the Church of England, by the time he had completed the necessary training, he found himself conscience-bound to resist Archbishop William Laud's emphases on liturgical ceremonialism and clerical hierarchy. He felt compelled, in political as well as ecclesial respects, to "the defense of liberty."

In his second chapter Jacobs provides an overview of the poem, but only after dealing with two preliminary considerations. The first few pages of the chapter sketch the significance of documents collected in the Trinity manuscript. These include drafts of poems and Milton's ideas for writing a biblical epic in English. By means of a few references to the manuscript, Jacobs establishes that Milton had been planning his epic for a long time and that the poem he finally wrote turned out to be different from what he had initially planned. Jacobs also considers briefly how best to characterize Milton's beliefs, concluding (rightly, I think) that Milton cannot be adequately characterized as a Quaker or a Puritan or a Calvinist. He walked his own path. Along the way, Jacobs mentions the heterodox *De Doctrina Christiana*, which he accepts as Milton's own, but decides not to "attempt to use" it "to elucidate the theology of *Paradise Lost*," since "The poem is its own project of theological inquiry and should be allowed to speak for itself."

The rest of chapter two reviews the poem, foregrounding "three major themes…that would dominate the post-Milton future: government, sexual politics, and theology proper." This selection, Jacobs is careful to remind us, produces a "simplified and distorted account, distorted to reflect the future life of the poem." Given his purposes, he presents "the poem as a series of musical movements." Books I-III lay out the governing concern of the poem: "the ways of God require justification" because "when God the Father could have destroyed Satan and the other rebel angels, he chose not to, and instead allowed Satan to come to this newly created

earth" to tempt Adam and Eve. Jacobs comments that "it would be hard to deny that such behavior requires justification. But this is a nettle Milton boldly grasps." Books IV-VIII introduce the beauty of the created order, including Adam and Eve, and Raphael warns them concerning their enemy. Book IX provides controversial backstory for the temptation and fall as well as describing the fall itself; Jacobs is most expansive here, introducing additional details from Milton's life as context for his representation of Eve (a lightning-rod drawing critical dispute almost since the poem's first publication). The final books of the poem (X-XII) deal with the aftereffects of the fall, including especially anticipations of God's gracious response to human sin in the future sending of the Son.

The book's remaining chapters offer a highly selective—but judicious and illuminating—series of episodes in the reception of the poem. Chapter three traces responses to the poem in its first hundred years. After the restoration of the monarchy, John Dryden (who had worked with Milton for a time in Cromwell's government) sought Milton's permission to develop "a dramatic adaptation of *Paradise Lost* in heroic couplets." Jacobs wonders whether Dryden's adaptation ought to be regarded as praising Milton or correcting him. Elsewhere Dryden is the first to suggest that Milton's poem represents Satan heroically, but he also compares Milton's greatness with the greatness of Homer and Virgil. A generation after Dryden, Joseph Addison praised the excellence of *Paradise Lost* while rejecting Milton's polemics in support of regicide. Addison recognizes that neither Adam nor Satan is the hero of the poem; as Jacobs explains, "in Milton's poem Messiah is the protagonist, Satan the antagonist, and Adam and Eve the field of battle." Samuel Johnson disliked Milton as a man but praised Milton's poem. In contrast with Addison, for whom Milton's treatment of Adam and Eve made the poem humanly interesting, Johnson thought the uniqueness of their unfallen condition a barrier to understanding for ordinary sinners like the rest of us. At the end of the poem's first century, William Cowper reverenced Milton's stature as a poet.

Jacobs tells the story of Milton's fortunes among the Romantics in chapter four. Blake's *Milton* imagines a "Purgatorial correction…directed at Milton's perverted theology and his cruelty to the women in his life." In Blake's imagination, Milton would now recognize that his poem made an idol of God by patterning God on earthly kings. Most famously, Blake claimed that "Milton was of the Devil's party without knowing it." Variations on this claim shape the responses of other Romantic writers, particularly "four members of the most extraordinary English family of that era: the Godwins and the Shelleys." Mary Wollstonecraft attacks Milton's representation of Eve. Though she admires "Milton's pleasing picture of paradisaical happiness" (her words), she is more impressed by the sublimity of Milton's Satan. William Godwin "follows Dryden in naming Satan as the hero of *Paradise Lost*." Percy Shelley compared his hero Prometheus with Milton's Satan, and Mary Shelley's

Frankenstein represents Victor Frankenstein as a creator who has abandoned his creation—implying, by means of her allusions to *Paradise Lost*, that God similarly abandoned Adam and Eve.

The opening pages of chapter five survey responses to Milton during the Victorian period. Several of these are entertaining (such as Mark Twain's assertion that "it meets [the] definition of a classic—something that everybody wants to have read and nobody wants to read"), but in Jacobs's assessment, "Generally speaking, the Victorian era proved to be one that domesticated or marginalized *Paradise Lost*." By the beginning of the twentieth century, the poem had become canonical, admired (by Virginia Woolf, for example) as impressive poetry, but somewhat baffling for secular readers because of its serious treatment of religious belief. "So far," Jacobs says after mentioning comments by Woolf and J. Middleton Murray and Ezra Pound and T. S. Eliot, "the twentieth-century responses to *Paradise Lost* are what one might expect of responses to assured classics: a chorus of respect interspersed with arias of protest. But in the middle third of the twentieth century a greater debate about Milton began." This "greater debate" moves beyond considering the merits or demerits of Milton's poetry to consider his belief.

The greater debate begins with Charles Williams, a relative outsider to the academic orthodoxy and a close friend of C. S. Lewis. In an introduction to Milton's poetry, "Williams took the contemporary questions about the qualities of Milton's verse as an opportunity to affirm his wholehearted agreement with Milton's theology; and in so doing, he set the readerly cat among the scholarly pigeons." Lewis's landmark *Preface to Paradise Lost* followed Williams, insisting on taking seriously Milton's Christianity. In *Preface* Lewis thus combines literary criticism with theological apologetics. In *Milton's God* William Empson accepts Lewis's claim that Milton's theology matters, but on Empson's reading the tensions in *Paradise Lost* expose the moral inadequacies of Christian orthodoxy. The third great landmark in this controversy is Stanley Fish's book *Surprised by Sin*, "a witty and brilliant attempt to explain, and to transcend, the argument between Lewis and Empson by declaring that both were right—and wrong." Fish insists that the moral ambiguities of *Paradise Lost* function as traps for the reader, effectively tempting the reader into faulty responses to Satan and sin in order to then correct the reader's understanding. Milton's poem requires a choice between "absolute faith and equally absolute unbelief, neither of which we ever want to accept *as* absolute."

Jacobs's final chapter traces echoes of *Paradise Lost* in popular culture. Several of these are intriguing: allusions in films, in novels, and in video games, as well as adaptations and translations. (I've added to my reading list Christopher Fry's libretto for Krzysztof Penderecki's operatic adaptation of *Paradise Lost*.) Perhaps the most interesting portion of this chapter is an account of Philip Pullman's *His Dark Materials*. Like Blake, Pullman regards Satan as heroically defiant; like Empson,

Pullman despises Christianity. Jacobs is fair but clear: "*His Dark Materials* is not a wholly successful work—the first book is utterly brilliant, but the subsequent volumes succumb to didacticism and a Manichaean sensibility" (Jacobs does not mention Pullman's particular antipathy for Lewis). Jacobs rightly recognizes that Pullman's description of Christianity "is cringe-inducingly simplistic." In an "Afterword," however, Jacobs agrees with Pullman's sense that *Paradise Lost* "will not go away."

Jacobs's biography of *Paradise Lost* will not shift the focus of Milton studies, though it might remind Milton specialists why they were attracted to Milton to begin with. For general readers, the book is an accessible, thought-provoking review of key moments from the history of the epic's reception. Jacobs makes rich use of well-chosen anecdotal material (don't neglect his footnotes), framed by his own clear prose.

In his conclusion, Jacobs quotes Milton to invite readers to "give [it] due audience, and attend" this poem. I second this invitation—and add to it my commendation of Jacobs's own book.

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Of Holy Indolence, the End of All Life

PAUL J. PASTOR

There is the plum tree snowing on the grass.
There is the road that leads up to the pass.
Now I will brightly think, and take my rest.
I will turn pink and sink into the West.

There is the bridge that spans the little creek.
There is the coffee mug I dropped last week.
I will give names to the marauding snail.
I will let spiders nest upon the mail.

There is a hymn within the thrush's moan.
There is a worm that curled and died alone.
I will try not to be a thing that kills.
I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills.

There is a prophet curled below the rose.
There is the Devil with his hunting nose.
I will open my hands, and not ask why.
I will turn bright and sink into the sky.

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About Mere Orthodoxy

We are a small group of Christians who since 2005 have been defending word count and nuance on the internet while working out what our faith looks like in public.

Whether it is arts, movies, literature, politics, sexuality, or any other crevice of the human experience, we believe that the Gospel has something to say about it and that "something" really can be good news.

We take our cues from C.S. Lewis and G.K. Chesterton, two of the most thoughtful, perceptive Christians of the twentieth century. One of them wrote Mere Christianity and the other wrote Orthodoxy, and we like those books so much we stapled their names together and took it as our own.

Their thoughtfulness wasn't abstract: it was rooted in the challenges and struggles that England was facing in their time, and their mission was to demonstrate how a classically minded, creedally centered orthodox Christianity was an attractive and persuasive alternative to the ideologies of their day.

And they did their work with words, with essays, poems, and stories.

Here's what we hope you will discover in our writing:

We are scripturally rooted and creedally informed. We know that it's not enough to simply say the Apostle's Creed and that the further we get from it, the more we'll disagree on the particulars of how Christianity should play out in public. But we also think that getting to the Apostle's Creed is a pretty good start for most Christians in our era, so that's where we'll put our baseline.

We're cheerfully contrarian when we have to be. We disagree with each other, and probably with you too (at least on something, right?). We think that's part of what makes life and writing interesting. So we'll make arguments, but hopefully in a way that is generous and kind.

We're eclectic. We could write about anything. Chasing our interests is the only thing that keeps us interesting, and being interesting is the one rule we have. Other publications may have a "niche," and Google loves them for it. Our niche is the world and where our reflections take us in it. And we kind of like it that way (and hope you will too).

We're publicly engaged. We're after the meaning and significance of things, the substance. Which means that we are after matters of public concern. And our hope is that you'll think more carefully, more deeply, and hopefully more Christianly about our world and your place in it after reading us.

THE APOSTLE'S CREED

We believe in God, the Father almighty,
creator of heaven and earth.

We believe in Jesus Christ, his only Son, our Lord,
who was conceived by the Holy Spirit
and born of the virgin Mary.
He suffered under Pontius Pilate,
was crucified, died, and was buried;
he descended to hell.
The third day he rose again from the dead.
He ascended to heaven
and is seated at the right hand of God the Father almighty.
From there he will come to judge the living and the dead.

We believe in the Holy Spirit,
the holy catholic church,
the communion of saints,
the forgiveness of sins,
the resurrection of the body,
and the life everlasting.

Amen.